

Art & Design

Year 8 · Student Course Book

Every child is an artist. Keep the studio open.

Year 8 art and design develops making, looking and thinking: drawing, colour, print, 3D and the artists who changed how we see.

INSIDE THIS BOOK

- Skills: drawing, paint, print, 3D
- Artists and movements in context
- Sketchbook habit and portfolio building
- Critique language and reflection
- Final project per unit

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Welcome

This book is your student course book for Year 8 Art & Design.

You will use it in class to look, think, experiment, make and keep evidence of your thinking. It is not only a reading book and not only a colouring book. It is both: places to understand ideas, and places to draw, write and reflect.

Path for every topic:

READ → LOOK → THINK → DISCOVER → TRY → CREATE → REFLECT

Welcome to Art & Design

Art is everywhere.

It can be found in paintings and sculptures, but also in photographs, films, buildings, clothes, posters, illustrations, objects, digital images, installations and the spaces around us. Sometimes art is carefully planned. Sometimes it is spontaneous. Sometimes it is beautiful. Sometimes it is strange, uncomfortable, confusing or even difficult to understand.

But what makes something art?

This is a much harder question than it first appears.

There is no single definition that explains every artwork ever made. Art has changed enormously throughout history, and different cultures have developed different ideas about what art is, what it should do and who can make it.

Artists do not simply make things. They observe, question, interpret, experiment and communicate ideas.

Throughout this course, you will be asked not only:

- “What can I make?”

but also:

- “Why am I making it?”
- “What am I trying to communicate?”
- “What choices could I make?”
- “What happens if I try something different?”

These questions are at the heart of artistic practice.

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IMAGE 0.01 - Ways of making. Purpose: show that Art & Design includes drawing, painting, photography, print, sculpture and collage.

By the end of Year 8 you can

- look more carefully than you did in Year 7
- develop an idea through research, experiment and refinement
- use drawing, photography, sculpture, collage and graphic design with purpose
- explain your choices using visual vocabulary
- present work in a portfolio and a small exhibition

What is Art & Design?

1. What is art?

One possible definition of art is:

Art is a way of communicating ideas, experiences, emotions and ways of seeing through creative forms.

But this definition is only a starting point.

Art can communicate something very specific, such as a person's face or a particular place. It can also communicate something much harder to describe: a feeling, a memory, a political idea, a dream or a question.

A portrait might tell us what someone looked like. It might also tell us how the artist felt about that person.

A photograph might record an event. It might also change the way we think about that event.

A sculpture might represent a human figure. It might also make us think about identity, power, memory or the human body.

This means that an artwork can contain several layers of meaning.

Description is not the same as interpretation

When looking at an artwork, begin by asking: **What can I see?**

This is description. You might notice colours, lines, shapes, textures, figures, objects, patterns, spaces, materials, light and dark areas.

Then ask: **What might it mean?**

This is interpretation. You might think that an artist has used dark colours to create a feeling of sadness, or that an unusual composition creates a sense of tension.

Finally, ask: **Why do I think that?**

This is where your interpretation becomes an argument rather than simply an opinion.

Compare these two statements:

- "I don't like this painting."
- "The limited colour palette and distorted figures make the painting feel uncomfortable, which I think supports the artist's intention to communicate anxiety."

The second statement gives reasons.

In Art & Design, you are encouraged to develop ideas that you can explain, question and support.

Curiosity

The word **art** has been used for skill, making and imagination across many cultures. There is still no single definition that everyone agrees on. People have been asking “What is art?” for centuries, and the answer keeps changing. That is part of what makes the subject interesting.

2. Why do people make art?

People have been making images and objects for thousands of years.

Long before photography, cinema or digital technology, people created drawings, paintings, sculptures, patterns and decorative objects.

People make art to:

- record what they see
- communicate with others
- express emotions
- tell stories
- preserve memories
- represent people and places
- explore identity
- celebrate beliefs and traditions
- question society
- protest or challenge ideas
- experiment with materials
- solve visual problems
- explore imagination
- create beauty
- make people think
- make people feel something

Sometimes an artist knows exactly what they want to communicate. Sometimes meaning develops while they are working. Sometimes the viewer finds a meaning that the artist never intended.

This is one of the interesting things about art: **an artwork does not always have only one meaning.**

The artist brings ideas and experiences to the artwork. The viewer brings their own experiences. The culture and historical period also influence how the artwork is understood.

Think like an artist

Imagine that you create a painting about a person you know. You intend it to be a celebration of that person. A viewer looks at it and sees loneliness.

Who is right? The artist? The viewer? Could both interpretations be valid?

Explain your answer in your sketchbook.

write your thinking

3. Does art have to be beautiful?

For a long time, people associated art with beauty. Paintings of beautiful landscapes, carefully painted portraits and perfectly balanced compositions were considered examples of artistic achievement.

But artists have never been interested only in beauty. Some artists deliberately create work that is disturbing, ugly, strange, shocking or difficult.

Why might an artist do this?

Imagine that an artist wants to communicate fear. Would a beautiful, peaceful image necessarily be the best way to communicate that feeling? Perhaps not.

They might instead use distorted forms, uncomfortable colours, aggressive marks, disturbing imagery, unusual materials or chaotic compositions.

The artwork may not be conventionally beautiful, but it may still be successful.

This leads to an important distinction: **something does not have to be beautiful to be meaningful.**

Equally, something can be beautiful without necessarily being a successful artwork. Beauty is subjective. What one person considers beautiful, another person may find boring or unpleasant.

Think like an artist

Can something be a successful artwork if you do not like looking at it?

What matters more: beauty, skill, meaning, emotion or the idea behind the work?

There may not be one correct answer. What matters is how well you can justify your opinion.

write your thinking

4. Who decides what is art?

If you walk into an art gallery, you expect to see artworks. But imagine that you see an everyday object displayed on a white pedestal. It might be an old chair, a bottle, a pile of clothes or a broken machine.

You might ask: “Why is that in an art gallery?”

This question has been asked many times throughout the history of modern art. Artists have challenged traditional ideas about what an artwork should look like and what materials artists should use.

An ordinary object can become part of an artwork because of the context in which it is presented and the ideas connected to it.

This means that sometimes the important question is not “What is this object?” but “Why has the artist chosen this object?”

The same object can have different meanings depending on where and how we encounter it.

- A chair in a classroom is furniture.
- A chair photographed as part of a project about loneliness might communicate something very different.
- A chair displayed in a gallery might become part of a conversation about objects, memory, design or everyday life.

Context changes meaning.



IMAGE 0.02 - An ordinary chair in a gallery. Purpose: show that context can change how we look at an everyday object.

Think like an artist

Look around the room. Choose one ordinary object. Imagine that you want to turn it into an artwork without changing the object itself.

Would you photograph it, place it somewhere unexpected, repeat it, enlarge it, isolate it, draw it, change the lighting, combine it with another object, or give it a new title?

How could you make people look at it differently?

write your thinking

Did you know?

In 1917 the artist Marcel Duchamp submitted a factory-made urinal, titled *Fountain*, to an exhibition. Whether you agree with that gesture or not, it forced a lasting argument: can the idea and the context be as important as the making? Museums still debate it more than a century later.

5. Can an idea be art?

Traditionally, we often think of art as something physical: a painting, a sculpture, a photograph, a drawing.

But what if the idea itself is the most important part?

Some contemporary artists create works where the concept is more important than the object. An artist might create an artwork based on an instruction, an action, a conversation, a performance or a situation.

This challenges a common assumption: **art does not always have to be an object that you can keep.**

Sometimes the artwork is the experience. Sometimes it is the process. Sometimes it is the idea.

This is one reason why contemporary art can initially seem confusing. Instead of asking “What is this supposed to be?”, try asking “What is the artist asking me to think about?”

6. Art and personal experience

No two people see the world in exactly the same way. Your experiences influence what you notice and how you interpret things.

Imagine looking at a photograph of an empty house.

- One person might think: “It looks peaceful.”
- Another might think: “It looks lonely.”

- Someone else might remember a house they once lived in.
- Another person might think about abandoned buildings.

The photograph has not changed. The viewer has.

This is why personal experience matters in art. Artists use their own experiences, memories, cultures, interests and observations to develop ideas. As an artist, you should not be afraid of bringing your own perspective into your work.

Your experiences are part of what makes your work different from somebody else's.

7. Looking at art

Learning to look is one of the most important skills in Art & Design.

Looking is not the same as seeing. We see thousands of things every day, but we do not always really observe them.

Artists train themselves to notice proportion, relationships between objects, subtle changes in colour, light and shadow, surface and texture, movement, negative space, patterns, details and unusual viewpoints.

When you draw from observation, you are not simply copying an object. You are learning to look carefully. You begin to notice things that you might previously have ignored.



IMAGE 0.03 - Memory versus observation. Purpose: compare a simplified memory sketch of a chair with a careful observational study of the same object.

A useful way to analyse art

When looking at an artwork, move through four stages.

1. **LOOK.** What can you actually see? Describe the visual information without interpreting it.
2. **ANALYSE.** How has the artist organised the visual elements? Think about line, shape, colour, tone, texture, space, composition and scale.
3. **INTERPRET.** What might the artwork communicate? What feelings, ideas or questions does it suggest?
4. **QUESTION.** What are you still unsure about? What would you like to know?

This last stage is important. You do not have to understand everything immediately. Being curious is part of being an artist.

8. What is design?

Art and design are closely connected, but they are not exactly the same.

Design usually begins with a purpose or problem. A designer might need to create a poster, a logo, a book cover, a website, a package, a chair, a building, clothing or an information graphic.

The designer has to make decisions about how something will look and how it will work. Design therefore involves both creative thinking and problem solving.

A successful design needs to communicate effectively to a particular audience. For example, a poster for a children's art exhibition should probably look very different from a poster advertising a serious financial conference.

The designer needs to consider:

- Who is this for?
- What does it need to communicate?
- How should it communicate it?

- What visual choices will make it effective?

9. Art or design?

The boundary between art and design is not always clear.

A poster can be visually beautiful and artistically expressive while also having a clear purpose. A building can be functional but also be considered an artwork. A photograph can document information while communicating personal ideas. A piece of clothing can be practical while also expressing identity.

This is why Art & Design are studied together. Both require observation, imagination, experimentation, decision-making, visual communication, problem solving and evaluation.

The difference is often related to purpose, but even this is not always straightforward.

Think like an artist

Imagine two objects that look exactly the same. One was created as a functional product. The other was created as an artwork.

If they look identical, what makes them different? Is it their purpose, the artist's intention, the context, the way they are presented, or does it matter at all?

write your thinking

10. Skill is not the same as creativity

Being able to draw realistically is a useful skill. Being able to control paint is useful. Knowing how to use a camera, editing software or a design programme is useful.

But technical skill alone does not make someone a creative artist.

Imagine two students. Student A can draw extremely accurately but always copies exactly what they see. Student B has less technical skill but constantly experiments, develops unusual ideas and finds personal solutions to problems.

Who is more creative? The answer is not necessarily simple.

Technical skill can help you communicate an idea, but creativity involves much more than technical accuracy. Creativity involves making connections, asking questions, taking risks, experimenting, solving problems, changing direction, learning from mistakes and developing original ideas.

You will therefore be encouraged to experiment throughout this course. A mistake is not necessarily a failure. Sometimes a mistake is information. It tells you something about what happens when you make a particular decision.

The sketchbook as a creative tool

Artists are often described as people who “make things”. But artists also think through making.

An artist may begin with a question rather than an answer. They might ask: What does identity mean? How can I show movement without drawing a moving person? How can a colour communicate a feeling? What happens if I remove most of the detail?

Making allows artists to investigate these questions. This is why your sketchbook is important. It is not simply a place for finished drawings. It is a place for thinking visually.

Treat your sketchbook as a studio brain, not a neat scrapbook.

Do	Avoid
Date every page	Waiting for a “perfect” first page
Label tests (blind contour, clay maquette)	Throwing away “ugly” warm-ups
Stick in tickets, textures, photos, type scraps	Only copying finished internet images
Write short notes in your own words	Copying long biographies
Record what failed and why	Pretending every page is a final

Warm-ups that look wrong can still be excellent practice. Neatness is not the same as learning.



IMAGE 0.04 - A working sketchbook. Purpose: show process pages (tests, notes, observations) rather than only finished drawings.

Remember

Your sketchbook is evidence of thinking. Examiners, teachers and future-you will care as much about how an idea grew as about the final piece.

Classroom expectations, materials and safety

Year 8 uses a wider range of materials than Year 7: drawing media, clay, cameras, collage, print scraps and graphic materials.



IMAGE 0.05 - Studio materials. Purpose: introduce the range of tools used this year, from graphite and charcoal to clay, camera and collage.

Studio kit

Keep ready	Why
HB, 2B, 4B, 6B pencils	map, mid-tone, dark tone
charcoal and putty rubber	soft tonal drawing; lift lights
fine liner / brush pen	contour, continuous line, type sketches
A4/A3 cartridge + sketchbook	tests and finals
clay, board, modelling tools	portrait sculpture
camera or phone camera	visual research
scissors, glue, collage papers	posters and mixed media
viewfinder (card window)	crop compositions

Studio kit and safety

Clay keep wet, cover, wash tools	Charcoal tap dust, do not blow	Craft knife cut away from hands
Glue / spray ventilate, cap tightly	Camera strap on, no climbing	Shared kit wipe, return, name it

IMAGE 0.06 - Studio kit and safety. Purpose: a quick visual checklist for materials and safe habits.

Studio safety

- Do not blow charcoal dust toward anyone. Tap the page over a bin.
- Clay: keep it damp in a bag; wash tools; do not put clay in sinks where it can block pipes.
- Craft knives: cut away from fingers, on a cutting mat, blades in when not in use.
- Glue sprays and solvents: only with teacher permission and ventilation.
- Cameras: strap on, no climbing for a “better shot”, respect people's privacy.
- Share kit. Wipe tables. Return named tools.

Classroom habits

Arrive ready to look. Listen during demonstrations. Use lesson time to make, not to decorate the cover of your book. Photograph work before you take it home. Write one sentence at the end of each lesson: What did I try, and what did I notice?

How to develop an Art & Design project

A strong artwork rarely appears fully formed in the artist's mind.

You may begin with a simple observation. Then you might make a drawing. You experiment with colour. You photograph something. You research another artist. You change the composition. You try a different material. You reject an idea. You return to an earlier idea. Eventually, something begins to emerge.

This process can be described as:

OBSERVE → RESEARCH → EXPLORE → EXPERIMENT → DEVELOP → REFINE → CREATE → REFLECT

You will use this process repeatedly throughout Year 8.

A studio process



IMAGE 0.07 - A studio process. Purpose: a reusable cycle for every Year 8 project, from observation to reflection.

Did you know?

Many professional studios keep “failed” tests on purpose. Fashion designer Paul Smith, architect Zaha Hadid's office, and countless painters pin discarded versions on the wall because a rejected idea often becomes the next idea. Process is not a delay. It is the work.

There is no single way to make art

Two artists can be given exactly the same subject and produce completely different artworks.

Imagine that the subject is: “A person standing in a doorway.”

One artist might create a realistic pencil drawing. Another might make an abstract painting. Another might photograph the doorway. Another might create a sculpture. Another might use collage. Another might turn the idea into a digital artwork.

None of these approaches is automatically the “correct” one. The important question is: **which approach best communicates your idea?**

This is one of the most important principles of Art & Design.

Your voice as an artist

As you progress through Year 8, you will be encouraged to make increasingly personal decisions. You may discover that you prefer certain materials, particular subjects, specific colours, realistic or abstract approaches, photography, drawing, painting, sculpture, collage, digital media or design.

You may also discover things that you dislike. That is useful too.

Developing your artistic voice does not mean finding one particular style and using it forever. It means becoming increasingly aware of how and why you make decisions.

Your work does not need to look like somebody else's work to be successful. Artists learn from other artists, but they also develop their own responses.

Looking, recording, experimenting and developing

You will often be asked to experiment in this course. Experimentation means trying something without knowing exactly what the result will be.

You might change a material, change the scale, work from an unusual viewpoint, combine techniques, distort an image, repeat a shape, change the colour, work very quickly, work very slowly, remove information or add unexpected elements.

Some experiments will work. Others will not. That is normal.

The purpose of experimentation is not to produce perfect work every time. It is to discover possibilities.

A useful artist does not ask only “Did this work?” They also ask “What did I learn from this?”

How to think like an artist

Throughout this course, try to develop the following habits:

- **Be curious.** Ask questions. Look closely. Investigate.
- **Be observant.** Notice details that other people might overlook.
- **Be experimental.** Try different possibilities before deciding what works best.
- **Be open-minded.** Do not reject an idea simply because it looks strange at first.
- **Take creative risks.** Sometimes the most interesting results come from trying something unfamiliar.
- **Learn from mistakes.** A failed experiment can still teach you something.
- **Make decisions.** Do not leave every decision to chance. Think about why you are choosing a particular material, colour, composition or technique.
- **Reflect.** Look back at your work and ask what you have learned.
- **Develop your own ideas.** Use references and inspiration, but do not simply copy.

Questions artists ask**About the subject**

- What am I looking at?
- What interests me about it?

- What have I noticed that I did not notice before?

About ideas

- What am I trying to communicate?
- What could this mean?
- Is there another way of looking at it?

About materials

- Why am I using this material?
- What does this material allow me to do?
- What happens if I use it differently?

About composition

- Where does the viewer look first?
- What is the most important part?
- Is there enough contrast?
- Does the composition create movement or balance?

About experimentation

- What happens if I change one element?
- What if I make it larger?
- What if I remove something?
- What if I combine two different ideas?

About evaluation

- What is successful?
- What is not working?
- Why?
- What could I change?
- What have I learned?

Reflecting on your work

Reflection is not a polite paragraph at the end. It is how you become a better artist.

After each project, write in full sentences:

1. What was I trying to communicate?
2. Which experiment taught me the most?
3. What would I change if I had one more lesson?
4. Which visual element or principle of design did I use on purpose?
5. What will I take into the next project?

Reflect

Keep a running list titled **My Year 8 decisions**. Add one line after every finished piece: material, idea, success, next step.

Your Year 8 Art & Design journey

This year, you will work with different subjects, materials and approaches.

You will explore people, architecture, photography, typography, graphic design, collage and mixed media, while developing your understanding of the visual elements and principles of design.

But the most important thing you will develop is not a particular technique. It is your ability to think visually.

You will learn to look carefully. You will learn to question. You will learn to experiment. You will learn to develop ideas rather than simply choosing the first idea that comes to mind. You will learn that the process of making can be just as important as the final result.

And you will learn that your artwork does not always have to provide an answer. Sometimes the most interesting artwork is the one that makes the viewer ask a new question.

Think like an artist

Before you begin Year 8, consider these questions. There are no single correct answers.

1. Does art need to have a meaning?
2. Can something be art if the artist did not intend it to be art?
3. Can an artwork be successful if most people dislike it?
4. Is technical skill necessary for creativity?
5. Who has the right to decide what counts as art?
6. Can an artwork have a meaning that the artist never intended?
7. Is copying ever part of learning to become an artist?
8. Can an ordinary object become extraordinary simply because we look at it differently?
9. Which is more important: the final artwork or the process of making it?
10. What could you make that nobody else in your class would think of making?

Do not worry about finding the “right” answers. Instead, be prepared to change your mind.

Changing your mind after seeing, thinking and learning something new is not a weakness. It is part of being an artist.

write your thinking

The artist's mindset

Look closely. Ask questions. Try something. Make mistakes. Try again. Develop your ideas. Make choices. Explain your thinking. Stay curious.

Art is not only about what you make. It is also about how you see, how you think and how you respond to the world.

Unit 8.1 - Portrait: People

A portrait is much more than a picture of someone's face.

When we look at a portrait, we are not only looking at a person's physical appearance. We may also be looking at their personality, emotions, relationships, memories, identity or the way another person sees them.

Artists have created portraits for thousands of years. Some portraits were made to record the appearance of powerful people. Others were created to remember family members, communicate identity, explore emotions or question what it means to represent another human being.

In this unit, you will explore the human face and figure in different ways.

You will begin with observation and proportion, then experiment with expressive drawing, movement and emotion. You will work with line, shape, positive and negative space and three-dimensional form before developing your own personal portrait project.

The aim is not simply to learn how to draw a face accurately.

The aim is to discover how many different ways there are to represent a person.

On the portrait desk today

A plaster head sits under a lamp. Next to it: charcoal, a lump of clay, and a photograph of someone you know.

Your teacher says: "This unit is not about making a pretty face. It is about looking at people, including how they move, feel and occupy space."



IMAGE 8.1.01 - Portrait studio. Purpose: set the materials and mood for Unit 8.1: drawing, observation and clay.

In this unit you will

- draw faces from observation, thinking about relationships between features
- use blind contour and continuous line to train looking
- explore emotion, character and expressive representation
- capture the figure in movement with gesture drawing
- compose overlapping figures and negative space
- build a clay portrait head
- develop a personal portrait outcome through research, experiment and refinement
- evaluate your work with an artist statement

Curiosity

Roman emperors put their faces on coins so people who would never meet them still recognised their power. Portraiture has always been about presence, not only about likeness.

Chapter 1 - Introduction to portraiture

What is a portrait?

A portrait is an artwork that represents a person.

It can be a drawing, a painting, a photograph, a sculpture, a print, a digital image, a mixed-media artwork, or even a combination of different forms.

A portrait does not necessarily have to show the entire face.

An artist might show only part of a person's face, the back of their head, their hands, their silhouette or even objects that suggest something about their identity.

This raises an interesting question: **How much of a person do we need to see to recognise who they are?**

A portrait can tell us something about someone's appearance, but it can also communicate something about who they are.



IMAGE 8.1.02 - Identity without a full face. Purpose: show that hands, objects, clothes and silhouette can still represent a person.

Portrait and identity

When you look at another person, you recognise many different features: the shape of the head, the eyes, eyebrows, nose, mouth, ears, hair, skin, facial proportions, expression and posture.

But identity is not only physical.

The clothes someone wears, their hairstyle, posture, objects they carry and the environment around them can also communicate something about them.

An artist therefore has many choices when creating a portrait. They must decide:

- What should I show?
- What should I leave out?
- What should be emphasised?
- How should I present this person?

Think like an artist

How much of a person do we need to see to recognise who they are? Could a pair of hands, a silhouette or a favourite object still be a portrait?

write: what I would show, and what I would leave out

Understanding facial proportions

When learning to draw a face, it is useful to understand some general relationships between its parts.

However, remember that these are **guidelines, not rules**. Every face is different.

A simplified construction might begin with an oval representing the head.

- A central vertical line can help establish the direction in which the head is facing.
- A horizontal guideline can help position the eyes.
- The nose and mouth can then be placed in relation to the other features.

Useful starting relationships:

- the eyes sit about halfway down the head
- the face is about five eye-widths across
- the bottom of the nose is about halfway from the eyes to the chin
- the mouth sits about one-third of the way from nose to chin
- the ears often line up with the brow and the base of the nose

The important thing is to think about **relationships** rather than isolated features.

Instead of thinking "I am drawing an eye," think: "Where is this eye in relation to the other eye, the nose and the edge of the head?"

This change in thinking is important.

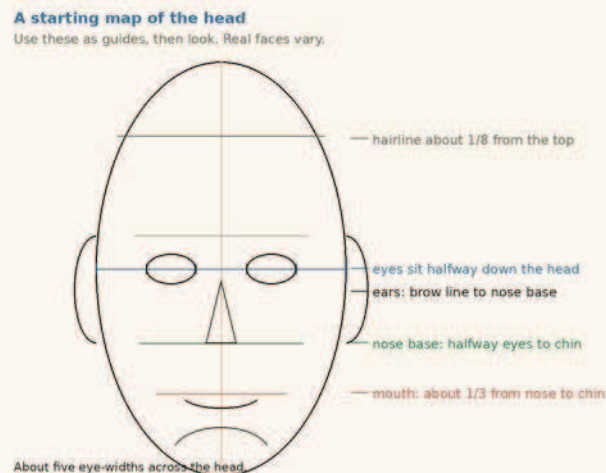


IMAGE 8.1.03 - A starting map of the head. Purpose: teach standard facial proportions as a guide before observation takes over.



IMAGE 8.1.04 - Observational portrait. Purpose: a careful graphite study using proportion, then looking at the unique face.

Drawing what you see

One of the most difficult things about portrait drawing is that we already have an idea of what a face should look like.

When we draw from memory, we often use symbols:

- two almond shapes for eyes
- a curved line for a nose
- a simple shape for the mouth
- hair represented by repeated lines

But real faces are much more complex.

Observational drawing means slowing down and looking carefully.

Ask yourself:

- What is the exact shape?
- Where does the line change direction?
- What is light?
- What is dark?
- Where are the shadows?
- What is the distance between the features?
- What shapes are created by the spaces around the face?

The visual elements in portraiture

Portraits can be analysed using the visual elements of art.

Element	In a portrait
Line	contours, wrinkles, hair and structure
Shape	constructing the face and organising the composition
Tone	light and dark areas create volume and depth
Colour	skin, environment, mood and atmosphere
Texture	skin, hair, clothing and other surfaces
Space	the space around the person changes how the portrait feels



IMAGE 8.1.05 - Visual elements in a portrait. Purpose: one study using line, tone, colour, texture and space on the same face.

Practical task: observational portrait study

Draw a portrait from direct observation. Do not worry about creating a finished artwork. Your objective is to look carefully.

Begin lightly and establish the overall shape of the head before adding details. Try to avoid drawing individual features too early.

observational portrait: overall head first, features later

Challenge: same person, structure first

Create a second drawing of the same person. This time, focus less on the details and more on proportions, large shapes, light and dark areas, and negative space.

Compare the two drawings. Which one communicates the structure of the face more successfully? Why?

second drawing: proportions, large shapes, light and dark, negative space

Think like an artist

If two portraits of the same person look completely different, which one is the "correct" portrait? Could both be correct? What makes a portrait recognisable?

write your thinking

Key words

portrait · identity · proportion · observation · visual elements · negative space

Chapter 2 - Expressive portrait drawing

A portrait does not always need to be realistic.

Artists can change, simplify, exaggerate or distort the appearance of a person to communicate ideas and emotions.

This is called **expressive representation**.

Instead of asking "How accurately can I copy this face?", you can begin asking "How can I make this face communicate something?"

Blind contour drawing

Blind contour drawing is an exercise that challenges the way we normally draw.

1. Place your subject in front of you.
2. Look at the subject rather than at your paper.
3. Slowly follow the edges and contours of the face with your eyes.
4. At the same time, move your pencil across the paper.
5. Try not to look down.

The resulting drawing may look strange. That is perfectly acceptable.

The purpose is not accuracy. It is to develop observation, concentration, hand-eye coordination, confidence and sensitivity to contour.

Why make a drawing that looks "wrong"?

A blind contour drawing can reveal something interesting.

When we stop trying to control the final image, we become more aware of what we are actually seeing. The drawing becomes a record of looking. It can also become an expressive artwork in its own right.

This reminds us that **a drawing does not always have to look realistic to be successful.**

Curiosity

The artist Henri Matisse sometimes drew portraits in a single flowing line after years of looking. The simplicity was earned. A confident simple line is not the same as a rushed empty one.

Continuous-line drawing

In a continuous-line drawing, try to keep your drawing tool in contact with the paper for as long as possible.

You might trace the outline of the head, facial features, hair, clothing, shadows and surrounding shapes.

The line becomes a journey through the image. Sometimes the line will cross itself. Sometimes it will move through empty space. Sometimes it will become almost abstract.



IMAGE 8.1.06 - Continuous-line and contour portraits. Purpose: show lively, imperfect line drawings that record looking rather than polish.

Experimenting with line

Line can have different qualities. It can be thin, thick, light, dark, smooth, broken, controlled, energetic, nervous, slow or fast.

Think about what these different qualities communicate.

- A delicate line might suggest fragility.
- A heavy line might create strength.
- A broken line might suggest uncertainty.
- A rapid, energetic line might communicate movement.

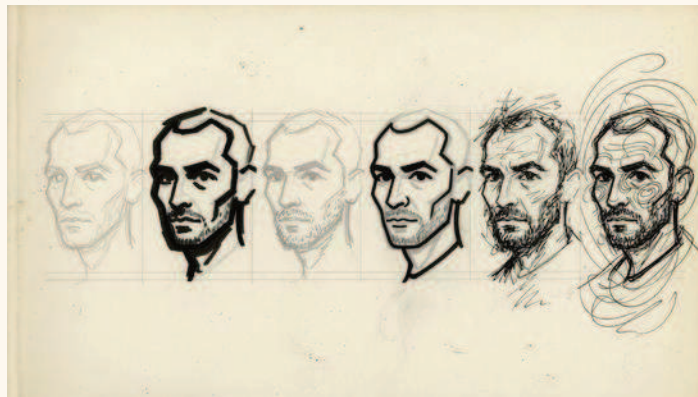


IMAGE 8.1.07 - Six line qualities, one face. Purpose: the same portrait changed by thin, heavy, broken, smooth, nervous and energetic line.

Experimental portraits

Now move beyond observation.

Experiment with distortion, repetition, exaggeration, fragmented faces, unusual proportions, overlapping features, changes in scale and unexpected line qualities.

Try several possibilities rather than deciding immediately which one is best. Your sketchbook should contain evidence of this experimentation.

Practical task: three portrait experiments

Create three different portraits of the same person.

1. **Portrait 1:** use continuous line.
2. **Portrait 2:** distort the proportions.
3. **Portrait 3:** use a combination of line, shape and experimental marks.

Do not try to make the three portraits look similar. Your goal is to discover how different approaches change the way we perceive the person.

portrait 1: continuous line

portrait 2: distorted proportions

portrait 3: line, shape and experimental marks

Think like an artist

If you deliberately distort someone's face, are you still creating a portrait? What makes something a portrait rather than simply an abstract image?

write your thinking

Studio note

Do not mock anyone's blind contour. These drawings are private training. Photograph them for your sketchbook if you do not want them on a wall.

Key words

expressive representation · blind contour · continuous line · distortion · exaggeration

Chapter 3 - Portraits and emotion

A face can communicate emotion without using words.

We can often recognise expressions such as happiness, sadness, anger, fear, surprise, confusion, boredom and excitement.

But emotions are rarely as simple as these categories suggest. A person can feel several things at once. A smile can be genuine, nervous, ironic or uncomfortable.

An artist can therefore use facial expression to create **ambiguity**.

How does the face communicate emotion?

Small changes can have a large effect.

Eyes. Are they open, closed, focused, looking away or looking directly at the viewer?

Eyebrows. Are they raised, lowered, relaxed or drawn together?

Mouth. Is it open, closed, smiling, tense or turned down?

Head position. Is the head tilted, lowered or raised?

Posture. Does the body appear relaxed, tense, defensive or energetic?

The whole body contributes to expression.



IMAGE 8.1.08 - Three emotions, one face. Purpose: show how brows, mouth and mark-making change character.

Character studies

A character study is an investigation into the appearance and personality of a person or imagined character.

Rather than creating one finished portrait immediately, make several studies.

Experiment with expressions, hairstyles, clothing, posture, viewpoint, lighting and scale. Think about what each decision tells the viewer.

Beyond "happy" and "sad"

Try representing more complex emotional states, for example: uncertainty, embarrassment, concentration, exhaustion, anticipation, suspicion, isolation, curiosity, confidence.

These emotions can be more interesting because they are less obvious.

Practical task: one person, five emotions

Create five quick portrait studies of the same person. Give each portrait a different emotional state.

Try to communicate the emotion without writing its name.

Ask a classmate to look at your drawings. Can they identify the emotions? If they interpret them differently from your intention, consider why.

five emotion studies of the same person (no labels)

Think like an artist

Does an artwork have to communicate exactly what the artist intended? If your viewer sees a different emotion from the one you intended, is the artwork unsuccessful?

write your thinking

Key words

expression · ambiguity · character study · posture · intention

Chapter 4 - Figure movement

Portraiture does not have to be limited to the head.

The human body can also communicate identity, emotion and character. A person standing still and a person running communicate very different things.

Movement can be suggested through gesture, posture, direction, repetition, line, overlapping forms and distortion.

Gesture drawing

Gesture drawing is a quick way of recording the movement and energy of the human figure.

The purpose is not to draw every detail. Instead, concentrate on:

- the direction of movement
- the position of the spine
- the angle of the shoulders
- the position of the hips
- the movement of the limbs
- the overall action

A gesture drawing might take only a few seconds.

Drawing quickly

When drawing a moving figure, there is not enough time to carefully construct every detail. This can actually be helpful. You are forced to make decisions.

Try several drawings: 30 seconds, 1 minute, 2 minutes.

Notice how the drawings change as you have more time. Which drawings communicate movement most effectively?

Line and movement

Line can create the impression of movement even when the figure itself is still.

- A curved line can suggest flow.
- A diagonal line can create energy.
- Repeated lines can suggest movement through time.
- An extended contour can lead the viewer's eye through the composition.



IMAGE 8.1.09 - Gesture drawings of moving figures. Purpose: show rapid line capturing weight, rhythm and action without detail.

Artists and movement

Artists have explored movement in many different ways. Some record the body realistically. Others simplify or distort it. Others use repetition or overlapping images to suggest several moments at once.

When researching artists, do not simply copy their style. Ask:

- What problem was this artist trying to solve?
- How did they represent movement?
- What could I learn from their approach?

Look up (in class, with sources recorded): Edgar Degas (dancers, unusual crops), Futurist painters such as Giacomo Balla (repeating limbs), Henri Cartier-Bresson (the "decisive moment" in photography). Steal a strategy: crop, repeat, blur, freeze. Do not copy their pictures.

Curiosity

Eadweard Muybridge photographed people and animals in motion in the 1870s using rows of cameras. His sequences taught artists that a galloping horse does not always have legs where painters had imagined them. Looking with new tools changes drawing.

Practical task: movement studies

Create a page of quick figure studies based on people moving. Try walking, running, jumping, stretching, turning, sitting and reaching.

Use expressive lines rather than detailed outlines.

movement studies: verbs only, expressive line

Challenge

Choose one gesture drawing and develop it into a more resolved figure study.

developed figure study from one gesture

Key words

gesture · line of action · posture · repetition · decisive moment

Chapter 5 - Overlapping figure studies

When several figures occupy the same space, they can overlap.

Overlapping creates relationships between forms and helps us understand depth. It can also create a sense of movement.

Imagine three drawings of a person walking placed on top of one another. The result might suggest different moments of the same action.

This is a useful way of thinking about **time and movement in a static image**.

Positive and negative space

Positive space is the space occupied by the subject.

Negative space is the space around and between the subject.

When drawing figures, students often concentrate only on the body. Artists also look at the shapes created by the empty spaces.

For example, the space between an arm and the body may form an unusual shape. That shape can be just as important as the arm itself.

Drawing the space around the figure

Try drawing the negative spaces first.

Instead of thinking "I am drawing a person," think "I am drawing these shapes."

This can help you become more accurate because you are no longer relying on your memory of what a person "should" look like.



IMAGE 8.1.10 - Overlapping figures and negative space. Purpose: show layered silhouettes creating depth, rhythm and gaps that matter.

Overlapping and composition

Overlapping figures can create depth, rhythm, movement, repetition, tension and visual complexity.

The position of each figure affects the whole composition. Ask:

- Which figure is dominant?
- Which one appears closer?
- Where does the viewer's eye move?
- Are the figures balanced?
- Is there enough empty space?

Practical task: overlapping figures

Create a composition using several figure studies.

Begin with one figure. Add a second figure, overlapping part of the first. Continue until you have created a sense of movement or rhythm.

Experiment with scale, transparency, line weight, direction, and positive and negative space.

overlapping figure composition: add one figure at a time

Extension

Use only line. Then create a second version using areas of tone or colour. Compare the results.

second version: tone or colour over the same overlap

Think like an artist

If several drawings of the same person overlap, are you showing several people or several moments in time? Can an image show time without becoming a film?

write your thinking

Key words

overlap · positive space · negative space · rhythm · composition

Chapter 6 - Portrait sculpture exploration

So far, you have represented people using two-dimensional images.

Now you will explore the portrait in three dimensions.

A sculpture occupies physical space. You can walk around it. You can see different sides. Light creates shadows across its surface.

This changes the way we think about representation.

From 2D to 3D

A drawing creates the **illusion** of form on a flat surface. A sculpture creates **actual** form.

Think about the difference between drawing a nose and building a nose from clay.

In a drawing, you use lines and tones to create the illusion of depth. In sculpture, the form must physically exist.

Understanding the head as a form

Before adding details, think about the head as a simple volume.

You might begin with an oval or sphere-like mass, a central axis, the position of the eyes, the direction of the face and the main planes of the features.

Do not begin by modelling individual details. Build the large forms first.

Clay techniques

Depending on the clay you are using, you may work through techniques such as:

Technique	What you do
Building	adding material to construct the form
Modelling	shaping and manipulating the clay with fingers and tools
Subtracting	removing material to create or refine forms
Joining	connecting separate pieces securely
Texturing	creating marks and surface qualities

The material itself can influence the final artwork.

The structure of the face

Think about the major forms: forehead, cheekbones, nose, eye sockets, mouth, chin, jaw, ears.

These forms create the structure of the head. The aim is not to make every detail perfect. Instead, try to understand how the different forms relate to one another.



IMAGE 8.1.11 - Building a clay head. Purpose: show clay as a structured, tactile material with tools, board and wet surface.

Expression in sculpture

Expression can also be communicated through three-dimensional form.

A change in the position of the eyebrows, the shape of the mouth, the angle of the head or the tension of the features can alter the character of the sculpture.

Surface texture can also influence expression. A smooth surface feels different from a rough, heavily marked surface.

Clay safety and care

Do not wash large amounts of clay down the sink. Wipe scraps into the reclaim bin. Wash hands. Cover work so it does not dry overnight unless you want leather-hard carving. Hollow thick heads so they dry evenly.

Practical task: clay portrait head

Create a portrait head in clay.

1. **Structure.** Build the main shape of the head.
2. **Features.** Establish the position and form of the facial features.
3. **Refinement.** Adjust proportions and relationships.
4. **Expression.** Develop a specific character or emotional quality.
5. **Surface.** Experiment with texture and marks.

Do not spend too long perfecting one feature while the rest of the sculpture is unfinished. Continually step back and look at the whole form.

Photograph four viewpoints (front, two sides, three-quarter) before you pack the work away.

plan the five stages / notes from looking at the whole form

Think like an artist

Is a sculpture more "real" than a drawing because it exists in three dimensions? Or is realism about something different from physical form?

write your thinking

Curiosity

Portrait sculpture is older than writing. The terracotta soldiers of Xi'an, Benin bronze heads, and Egyptian funerary portraits all used the head as a way to keep a person present. Different cultures, same need: to hold a likeness in three dimensions.

Key words

form · plane · modelling · subtracting · texture · expression

Chapter 7 - Personal portrait project

You are now ready to develop your own portrait project.

This project is an opportunity to bring together the ideas and techniques you have explored throughout the unit.

You are not expected to simply repeat one of the exercises. You should make decisions about subject, viewpoint, materials, technique, composition, emotion, colour, scale and meaning.



IMAGE 8.1.12 - A personal mixed-media portrait. Purpose: show a developed outcome that combines drawing and collage rather than a copied photograph.

Step 1 - Choose your subject

You might choose yourself, a friend, a family member, an imagined person, a historical figure, a fictional character or a group of people.

Think about why your subject interests you.

Step 2 - Research

Find visual references that can help you develop your idea. Research might include artists, photographers, portrait traditions, facial expressions, materials, techniques and compositions.

Do not simply collect images. Annotate them. Explain:

- What interests me about this image?
- What could I learn from it?
- How could I develop this idea in my own way?

Step 3 - Generate ideas

Create several possible approaches. Try different viewpoints, compositions, materials, expressions, colour schemes, levels of realism and degrees of abstraction.

Do not choose your first idea automatically. Give yourself alternatives.

Step 4 - Experiment

Choose some of your ideas and test them. You might create small drawings, photographs, colour studies, material experiments, collages, digital experiments or sculptural studies.

Record your experiments in your sketchbook. Write short notes about what you discover.

Step 5 - Develop

Select the most successful ideas. Combine them. Change them. Make them stronger.

This is the stage where your project should begin to become personal. Ask: **What makes this my artwork rather than simply an exercise?**

Step 6 - Refine

Before creating the final outcome, make decisions about scale, composition, materials, colour, technique and presentation.

Make a final plan. Consider what could go wrong and how you might respond.

Step 7 - Create

Now produce your final portrait.

Remember: the final artwork is important, but the decisions that led to it are also part of the project. Do not be afraid to adapt your plan if you discover something better while working. Artists often change their ideas during the making process.

Step 8 - Reflect

When your artwork is finished, step away from it. Look at it as if you were seeing it for the first time.

About the idea. What was I trying to communicate? Did the final work communicate this?

About the visual elements. How have I used line, shape, colour, tone, texture and space?

About the process. Which experiment was most useful? What problem did I encounter? How did I solve it?

About the final outcome. What is successful? What would I change? What did I learn?

Project requirements

- a title
- process pages in the sketchbook (not only the final)
- at least two materials or techniques combined or compared
- an 80-120 word artist statement
- a photograph of the final for your portfolio (Chapter 27)

Plan your eight steps

Write one sentence for each step: subject, research, ideas, experiment, develop, refine, create, reflect.

eight-step plan and three composition thumbnails

Key words

brief · research · development · refinement · personal voice

Chapter 8 - Review and project completion

Completing an artwork does not mean the learning process has finished.

Reflection allows you to understand your own creative decisions. It also helps you make better decisions in future projects.

Looking back at your process

Place your first experiments next to your final artwork. Compare them.

What changed?

Perhaps your original idea was realistic but became more expressive. Perhaps you planned to use one material but discovered another worked better. Perhaps your composition changed. Perhaps the

meaning of the work developed as you experimented.

These changes are not evidence that you failed to follow your plan. They are evidence that you developed your idea.

The importance of process

A successful sketchbook should show a journey.

It should contain:

research → observation → experiments → ideas → development → decisions → final outcome → reflection

A page full of perfect drawings but no evidence of thinking does not necessarily demonstrate more learning than a page containing unsuccessful experiments.

Your sketchbook should show how you think.

Final self-assessment

Answer the following questions honestly.

Focus	Question	My answer
Observation	How has your ability to observe faces and figures changed?	
Technique	Which drawing technique was most useful to you?	
Experimentation	Which experiment surprised you?	
Risk-taking	When did you take a creative risk?	
Development	How did your original idea change?	
Personal voice	What makes your final portrait personal to you?	
Reflection	What would you do differently if you repeated the project?	

self-assessment: write in full sentences

Artist's checklist

Before completing your project, make sure you have:

- ☐ Made observational portrait studies.
- ☐ Explored facial proportions.
- ☐ Experimented with expressive line.
- ☐ Tried blind contour or continuous-line drawing.
- ☐ Explored facial expression and emotion.

- ☐ Created figure movement studies.
- ☐ Investigated positive and negative space.
- ☐ Explored overlapping figures.
- ☐ Experimented with three-dimensional portraiture.
- ☐ Researched relevant artists or visual references.
- ☐ Developed several ideas for a personal portrait.
- ☐ Recorded experiments in my sketchbook.
- ☐ Developed and refined my strongest idea.
- ☐ Created a final outcome.
- ☐ Reflected on my process and final work.

Key vocabulary

Term	Meaning
Portrait	an artwork representing a person
Proportion	the relationship between the sizes of different parts of a subject
Observation	looking carefully in order to record what you actually see
Contour	the visible edge or outline of a form
Gesture	a quick drawing that captures the movement and energy of a figure
Expression	the way emotion or character is communicated through the face or body
Distortion	deliberately changing the appearance or proportions of something
Positive space	the area occupied by the main subject or forms
Negative space	the empty area surrounding or between forms
Composition	the organisation of visual elements within an artwork
Form	a three-dimensional shape or object
Texture	the visual or tactile quality of a surface
Experimentation	trying different possibilities to discover what works
Development	the process of changing and improving an idea
Refinement	making deliberate adjustments to strengthen an artwork
Identity	the qualities and characteristics that communicate who a person is

Think like an artist

You have now explored the portrait from several different perspectives. You have drawn faces, distorted faces, explored emotion, drawn movement, investigated positive and negative space, built a portrait in three dimensions and developed your own response.

Now return to the question you encountered at the beginning: **What is a portrait?**

Has your answer changed?

Perhaps a portrait is not simply an image of someone's face. Perhaps a portrait is an interpretation of a person. It can show what someone looks like. It can suggest how they feel. It can communicate how the artist sees them. It can reveal something about identity. And sometimes, it can tell us as much about the artist as it does about the person being represented.

Final question. If a portrait shows us how one person sees another person, can any portrait ever be completely objective?

Think about your answer. Then look at your own final portrait.

What does your portrait tell us about the person you represented, and what does it tell us about you?

final question: what the portrait tells about them, and about you

Unit 8.2 - Built Environment

Look around you.

The world we live in is full of designed and constructed spaces: houses, schools, bridges, streets, churches, shops, towers, pavements, walls and public buildings.

We often move through these spaces without really looking at them.

An architect, artist or photographer may see something completely different.

A wall can become a pattern of shapes and textures. A window can become a geometric composition. A staircase can create a rhythm of lines. A building can become an abstract image.

The **built environment** is everything around us that has been constructed or designed by people. It includes both individual buildings and the larger spaces they create.

In this unit, you will learn to look at architecture in new ways.

You will explore shape and form, proportion and scale, perspective, texture, positive and negative space, line, photography, cropping, unusual viewpoints, abstraction and mixed media.

You will gradually move from observing architecture to transforming it.

The aim is not simply to draw buildings accurately.

The aim is to discover how architecture can become a starting point for artistic ideas.

On the architecture desk today

A camera, a graphite stick, a piece of brick-patterned paper, and a window. The school itself is the subject.

Your teacher says: "Buildings are designed objects you walk through. This unit trains you to see structure, texture and viewpoint, then to make images that are more than postcards."



IMAGE 8.2.01 - Built environment desk. Purpose: introduce architecture as something you record, photograph and reconstruct.

In this unit you will

- look at buildings as collections of visual elements
- draw architecture from different viewpoints
- use one-point and two-point perspective as tools, not as a cage
- collect visual and tactile texture
- reconstruct a half-image, then interpret it
- take a line for a walk through architecture
- photograph unusual viewpoints, zoom and crop
- build mixed-media compositions from your research
- evaluate how observation became transformation

Chapter 9 - Introduction to architecture

What is architecture?

Architecture is the art and design of creating buildings and spaces.

It is also a practical discipline. A building needs to work. People need to be able to enter it, move through it and use it safely.

But architecture can also communicate ideas. A building can communicate power, tradition, technology, religion, identity, wealth, simplicity, openness, security or innovation.

Architecture therefore exists somewhere between **function** and **expression**.

Curiosity

The word **architecture** comes from Greek roots meaning "chief builder". For a long time the architect was both engineer and artist. Many famous sculptures of the twentieth century are actually buildings you can enter.

Looking at buildings as artists

When we look at a building, we often think about what it is used for.

An artist can look at it differently. Instead of thinking "This is a school," you might notice repeated windows, geometric shapes, strong vertical lines, areas of shadow, rough surfaces, reflections, patterns and symmetrical forms.

The building becomes a collection of visual elements.

This is an important artistic skill: **learning to see familiar things in unfamiliar ways**.

Shape and architecture

Architecture is full of shapes. Look for squares, rectangles, triangles, circles, arches, irregular shapes and geometric patterns.

These shapes can be repeated, combined and transformed. A building can therefore become almost like a drawing made in three dimensions.

Form

A **shape** is two-dimensional. A **form** has three dimensions.

A square can become a cube. A circle can become a sphere or cylinder. A rectangle can become a block or building.

Architects combine forms to create structures. Artists can simplify those structures to create new compositions.

Texture

Architecture contains many different surfaces: brick, stone, concrete, glass, wood, metal, tiles, painted walls, weathered surfaces.

Some textures are smooth. Others are rough. Some are regular. Others are irregular.

Texture can make an architectural drawing much more interesting.



IMAGE 8.2.02 - Observational building study. Purpose: a graphite street drawing with receding forms and window grids.

Observational studies

Choose a building or architectural detail.

Do not try to draw the entire building immediately. Instead, make small studies of one window, a doorway, a wall, a roof, a staircase, a decorative detail or a section of pavement.

Focus on what you can actually see.



IMAGE 8.2.03 - Small architectural studies. Purpose: collect windows, doors, walls, stairs and details before drawing the whole building.

Practical task: architectural observation

Create a page of small architectural studies. Each study should focus on a different visual element.

Try to record: shape → form → line → texture → shadow

Do not worry about making the page look finished. The purpose is to collect visual information.

architectural studies: shape, form, line, texture, shadow

Think like an artist

Why might an artist choose to draw only one small part of a building instead of the whole building? Can a detail sometimes tell us more than the whole?

write your thinking

Key words

architecture · built environment · shape · form · texture · observation

Chapter 10 - Architectural drawing warm-up

Architecture provides an excellent opportunity to study **perspective**.

Perspective is a system used to create the illusion of depth on a flat surface. Without perspective, buildings can appear flat. With perspective, we can suggest that forms extend backwards into space.

What is perspective?

When you look down a long road, the sides of the road appear to move closer together as they become more distant. Railway tracks appear to meet in the distance. Buildings become smaller as they move away from us.

This is called **linear perspective**. Artists use perspective to create the illusion of three-dimensional space.

One-point perspective

In one-point perspective, lines that move away from the viewer appear to meet at a single point.

This point is called the **vanishing point**.

Imagine standing in the middle of a corridor. The edges of the corridor appear to move towards one point in the distance. That point is the vanishing point.

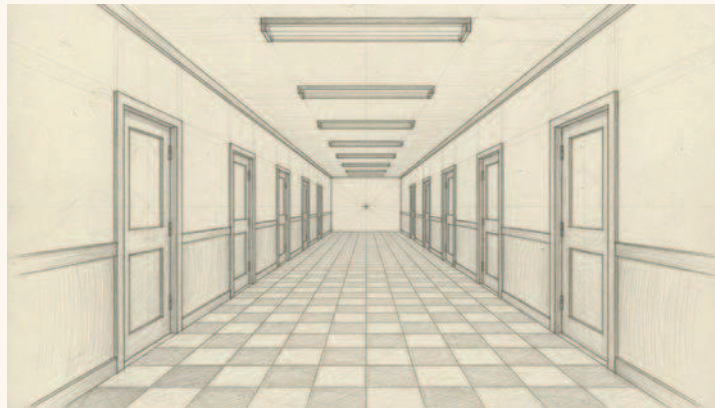


IMAGE 8.2.04 - One-point perspective. Purpose: a corridor receding to a single vanishing point.

Two-point perspective

Buildings are often easier to draw using two-point perspective.

Imagine standing at the corner of a building. You can see two sides. The horizontal edges of each side appear to move towards different vanishing points.

This creates a more convincing sense of depth.



IMAGE 8.2.05 - Two-point perspective. Purpose: a corner building with construction lines meeting two vanishing points.

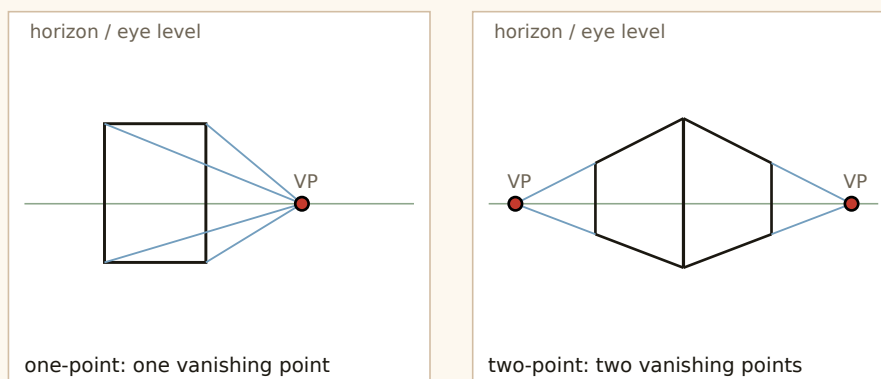


IMAGE 8.2.06 - One-point and two-point compared. Purpose: labelled vanishing points, horizon and eye level.

Multiple viewpoints

A building can look completely different depending on where you stand.

You might view it from the front, from the side, from above, from below, from a corner, from a distance or very close up.

Changing viewpoint changes the composition.

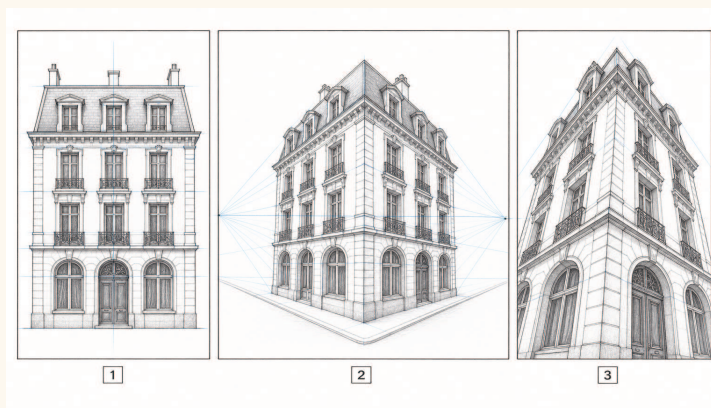


IMAGE 8.2.07 - Same building, three viewpoints. Purpose: front, corner and unusual view of one structure.

Practical task: same building, different views

Choose one building. Create three quick drawings from different viewpoints.

1. **View 1:** front view.
2. **View 2:** corner or side view.
3. **View 3:** an unusual viewpoint.

Compare the three drawings. Which one creates the strongest composition?

view 1: front

view 2: corner or side

view 3: unusual viewpoint

Perspective is not a rulebook

Perspective is useful, but artists do not always have to follow it exactly.

Some artists deliberately distort perspective. Others flatten space completely. Some combine several viewpoints in the same artwork.

The important thing is to understand perspective well enough to decide when to use it and when to challenge it.

Think like an artist

If an artist deliberately makes a building look impossible, is the drawing unsuccessful? Or can breaking the rules be part of the artistic idea?

write your thinking

Perspective is a tool

If the drawing feels stiff, you used the system more than your eyes. Keep the vanishing points, but vary tone and texture so it does not look like a worksheet.

Key words

perspective · vanishing point · horizon · eye level · viewpoint

Chapter 11 - Texture collection

Texture is one of the most interesting aspects of the built environment.

Walk through a city or neighbourhood and look closely. You might find cracked concrete, peeling paint, rough stone, rusty metal, patterned tiles, brick walls, glass reflections and wooden surfaces.

These textures can become visual material for an artwork.

Visual and tactile texture

Tactile texture is something we can physically feel. A rough wall feels different from a smooth glass window.

Visual texture is texture that we see but cannot physically touch. An artist can create the appearance of roughness using line, tone, pattern, repeated marks, paint, collage or photography.

Texture rubbings

A rubbing is a simple way of recording texture.

Place a sheet of paper over a textured surface. Rub a pencil, crayon or other drawing material across the paper. The texture of the surface creates a pattern.

Experiment with different pressures and materials.

Collecting texture

Do not collect only "beautiful" textures. Look for contrast.

Find: smooth and rough, regular and irregular, light and dark, old and new, natural and manufactured, damaged and perfect.

These differences can create interesting compositions.



IMAGE 8.2.08 - Architectural texture board. Purpose: brick, paint, metal, stone and a rubbing as a visual library.

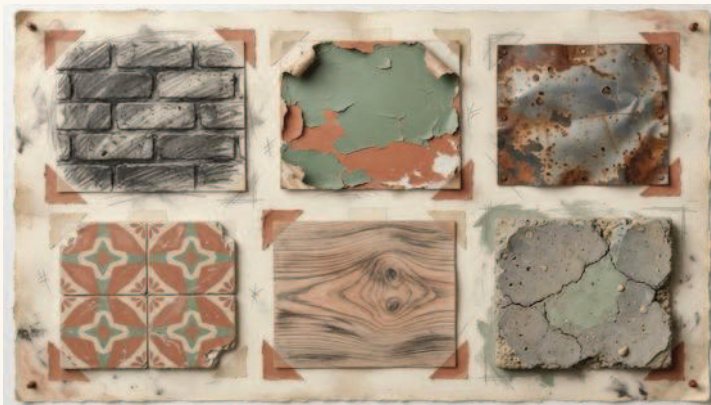


IMAGE 8.2.09 - Texture library. Purpose: six recorded surfaces, including rubbings, ready to use in mixed media.

Practical task: texture library

Create a collection of at least six architectural textures.

For each one, record: Where did you find it? What material is it? How does it feel visually? How could you use it in an artwork?

You can combine rubbings, drawings, photographs and written notes.

texture library: six surfaces with notes

From texture to pattern

A texture can become a pattern when it is repeated.

Try taking one small section of a texture and repeating it. What happens?

The original surface may become unrecognisable. This is one way artists transform observation into abstraction.

Think like an artist

When does a texture stop being a record of a real surface and become an abstract pattern?

write your thinking

Curiosity

Architects specify materials with samples called swatches, just as fashion designers do. A building is a giant texture collage that has to survive rain.

Key words

tactile texture · visual texture · rubbing · contrast · pattern

Chapter 12 - Half-image study

Artists often use incomplete information to challenge the viewer.

In this activity, you will work from part of an architectural image and reconstruct what you think the missing section might look like.

This is an exercise in observation and visual reasoning.

Looking for clues

When part of an image is missing, look carefully at what remains.

Look for lines, shapes, perspective, patterns, textures, repetition, symmetry and shadows.

These clues can help you predict what might continue beyond the visible area.

Reconstructing an image

Begin by studying the existing half. Do not immediately draw what you think should be there. Look at the evidence.

- If a line enters the missing area, ask: Where would this line logically continue?
- If a pattern repeats, ask: How might the pattern continue?
- If a building is symmetrical, ask: Would the other side mirror this structure?

Observation versus imagination

There is an important distinction between **reconstructing** and **inventing**.

At first, try to reconstruct the missing information as accurately as possible.

Then consider what would happen if you deliberately changed it.

This creates an opportunity to move from observation into artistic interpretation.



IMAGE 8.2.10 - Half-image reconstruction. Purpose: photograph on one side, observational drawing completing the building on the other.

Practical task: complete the architecture

Complete a partially visible architectural image. Focus on line, proportion, perspective and texture.

When you finish, compare your reconstruction with the original image if it is available.

Reflection. Where were you accurate? Where did you make assumptions? What clues helped you most?

complete the missing half from clues

Extension: change the reality

Create a second version. This time, allow yourself to change the missing section.

You might distort the architecture, change the scale, introduce unexpected shapes, alter the perspective or transform the texture.

Compare the two versions. One is based mainly on observation. The other is based more on interpretation.

second version: invent the missing half

Think like an artist

If you reconstruct a building "wrong" but the drawing still feels structurally true, have you failed the task or discovered a new building?

write your thinking

Key words

reconstruction · symmetry · clue · interpretation · invention

Chapter 13 - Single-line drawing

A single line can travel a long way.

It can describe an object, connect different forms and lead the viewer's eye through an image.

In this activity, you will explore the idea of **taking a line for a walk**.

What can a line do?

A line can describe an edge, divide space, create a shape, suggest movement, connect forms, create rhythm, lead the eye and communicate energy.

In architecture, lines are everywhere: walls, windows, doors, cables, stairs, railings, rooftops, pavements.

Continuous-line drawing

Begin at one point. Allow your line to travel through the architectural environment. Try to keep your drawing tool on the page.

You do not need to record every detail. Choose the elements that interest you.

The line may change direction, cross itself, become larger, become smaller or move into empty space.

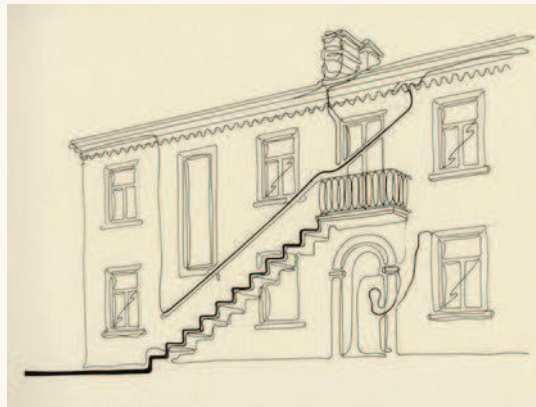


IMAGE 8.2.11 - A line walking through a facade. Purpose: one unbroken ink line travelling across architecture, between observation and abstraction.

Slow and fast lines

Try drawing the same architectural subject twice.

Drawing A. Work slowly.

Drawing B. Work quickly.

How does the quality of the line change?

The slow drawing may be more controlled. The fast drawing may be more energetic. Neither is automatically better. They communicate different qualities.

From drawing to abstraction

As your line moves through the building, the original subject may become less obvious.

Windows become rectangles. Stairs become diagonal lines. Walls become shapes.

Eventually, the drawing may begin to look abstract.

This is an important artistic transformation: **you can begin with something you see and end with something you imagine.**

Did you know?

Paul Klee taught at the Bauhaus, a school that treated art, craft and architecture as one problem. He described drawing as taking a line for a walk. A line that "walks" is close to how an architect's eye walks a plan.

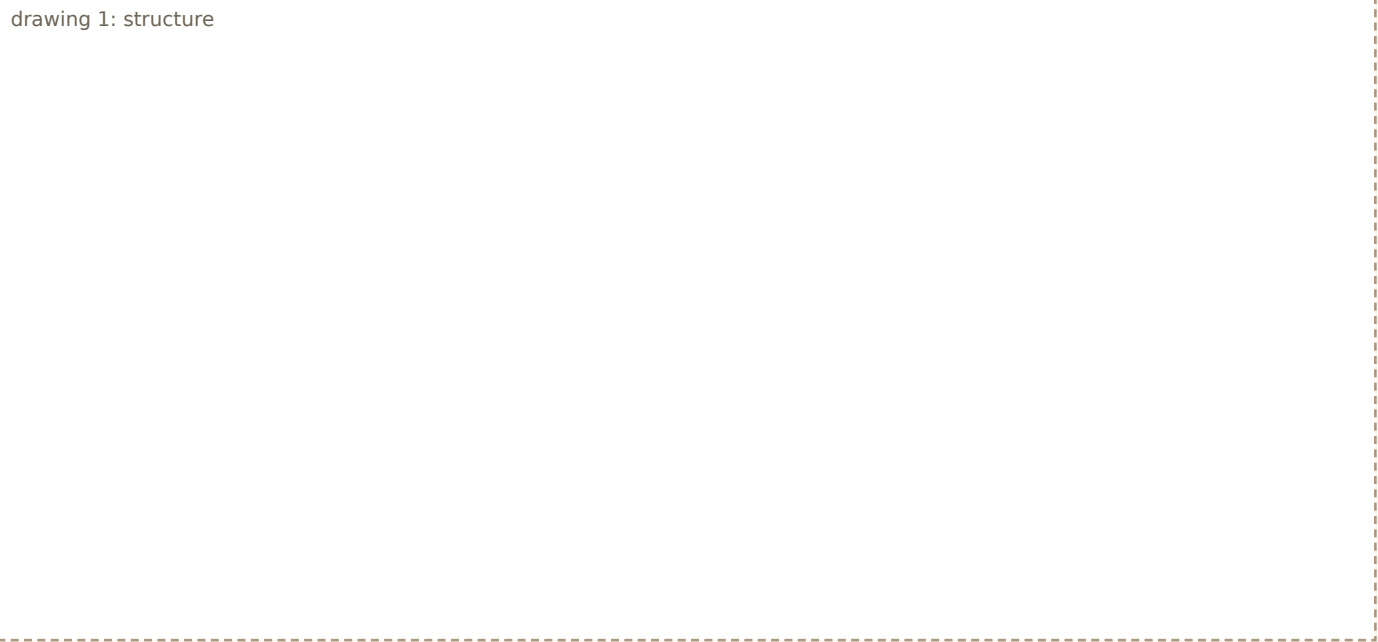
Practical task: take a line for a walk

Create three continuous-line architectural drawings.

1. **Drawing 1:** focus on structure.
2. **Drawing 2:** focus on texture.
3. **Drawing 3:** allow the line to become increasingly abstract.

Compare the three. At what point does the drawing stop looking like architecture?

drawing 1: structure



drawing 2: texture

drawing 3: towards abstraction

Think like an artist

Does an abstract artwork have to begin with an abstract idea? Can abstraction grow from careful observation?

write your thinking

Key words

continuous line · contour · rhythm · abstraction · energy

Chapter 14 - Photography and viewpoints

Photography allows us to explore architecture in ways that drawing alone cannot.

A camera can isolate details, magnify surfaces, crop information, freeze a moment, change perspective, distort scale and record light and shadow.

The camera does not simply record reality. The photographer makes choices about what the viewer is allowed to see.

Looking through the camera

When photographing a building, ask:

- What am I choosing to include?
- What am I choosing to exclude?
- Where am I standing?
- What happens if I move closer?
- What happens if I move further away?
- What happens if I photograph upwards?
- What happens if I photograph downwards?

These decisions affect the meaning and visual impact of the image.

Unusual viewpoints

Try photographing architecture from ground level, looking upwards, looking down, from very close, from a distance, through another object, reflected in glass, as a shadow or as a fragment.

An unusual viewpoint can make a familiar building look unfamiliar.

Zoom and detail

Zooming into a building can remove information. The viewer may no longer know exactly what they are looking at.

A small section of a wall might look like an abstract composition. This can be useful. You are transforming architecture from a subject into a visual resource.

Cropping

Cropping means removing part of an image.

A photograph can be cropped to emphasise a detail, remove distractions, change the composition, create tension or make the subject ambiguous.

Sometimes a crop can be more visually interesting than the original photograph.



IMAGE 8.2.12 - Unusual viewpoint. Purpose: a steep upward crop that turns a facade into repeating geometry.

Photography etiquette

Ask before photographing people. Do not photograph in toilets, changing rooms or private houses. Stay on the ground unless a teacher takes you to a safe viewpoint. No climbing.

Practical task: architectural photo hunt

Take a series of photographs of the built environment. Try to collect:

1. one image showing the whole building
2. one close-up detail
3. one unusual viewpoint
4. one texture
5. one reflection
6. one image where the architecture becomes almost abstract

Do not simply photograph "interesting buildings". Look for interesting visual relationships.

photo hunt plan / contact-sheet notes (whole, detail, viewpoint, texture, reflection, abstract)

Think like an artist

When you crop a photograph so much that the building is no longer recognisable, are you still photographing architecture? Or have you created an abstract photograph?

write your thinking

Key words

crop · zoom · viewpoint · reflection · fragment

Chapter 15 - Mixed-media development

You have now collected drawings, textures and photographs.

The next step is to combine them. This is where observation becomes transformation.

Mixed media means using more than one material or medium within the same artwork.

You might combine drawing, photography, collage, paint, printed textures, pencil, ink and digital images.

Why combine different media?

Different materials behave differently.

A photograph can record detail. A drawing can simplify. Paint can cover. Collage can fragment. Line can connect. Texture can create physical or visual interest.

When you combine them, you create new possibilities.

Cropping

Begin with one architectural photograph. Crop it. Try several different crops.

Notice how each one changes the composition. A small crop can become almost completely abstract.

Overlapping

Place one image over another. Experiment with transparency, scale, rotation, alignment and repetition.

Overlapping can create depth and complexity. It can also create visual confusion. Sometimes confusion is useful.

Abstraction

Abstraction does not necessarily mean creating something random.

It can involve simplifying, fragmenting, exaggerating, repeating, rearranging and transforming.

You might begin with a photograph of a building and gradually remove its obvious architectural features.

The result may still be connected to the original building, even if the viewer cannot recognise it.

Composition

As you develop your mixed-media work, think carefully about composition. Ask:

- Where is the focal point?
- Where does the eye travel?
- Are some areas too busy?
- Is there enough contrast?
- Are the shapes balanced?
- Do the layers work together?
- Is there a sense of depth?

Do not add more simply because you can. Every element should contribute something.



IMAGE 8.2.13 - Mixed-media architecture. Purpose: layered photo, drawing, rubbing and collage into one composition.

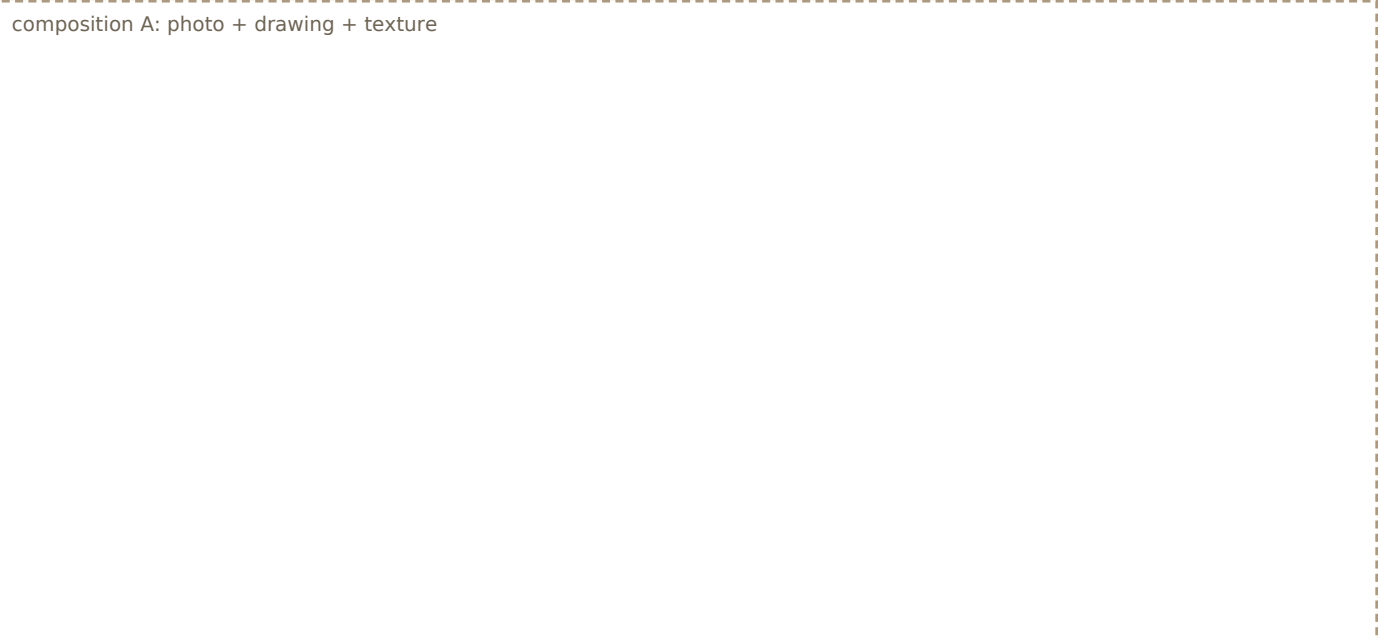
Practical task: mixed-media architecture

Create a series of experimental compositions using your architectural material.

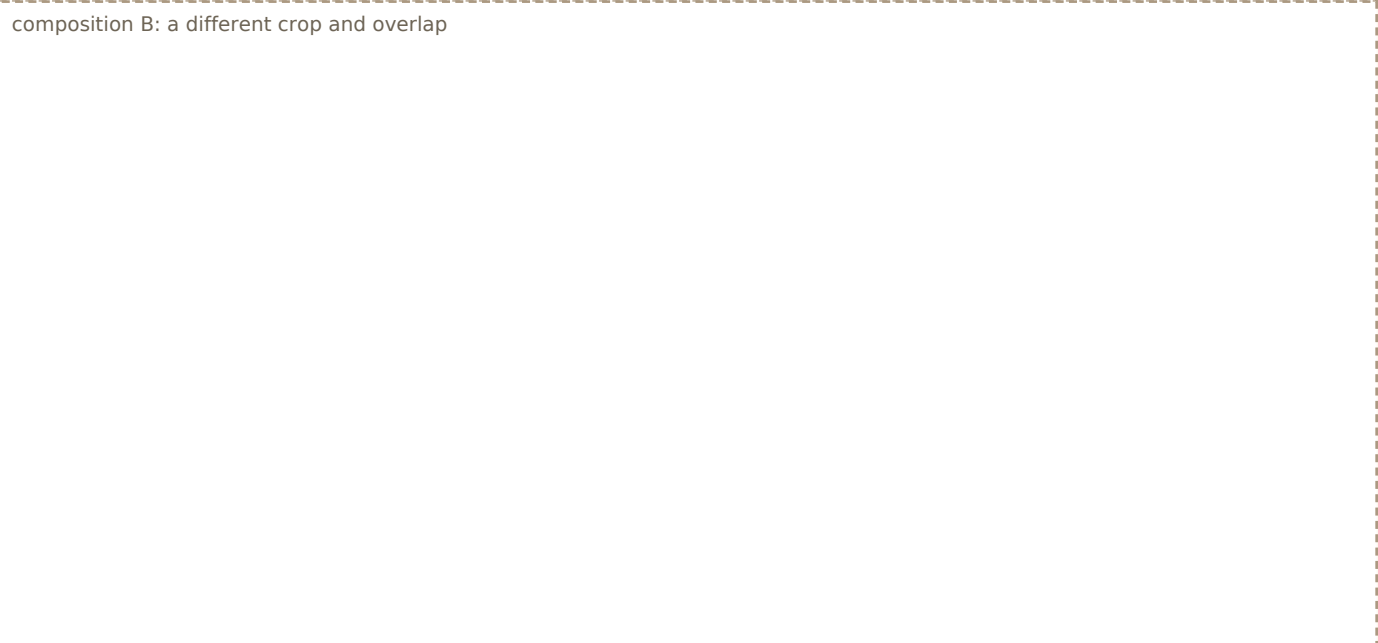
Begin with a photograph. Add a drawing. Introduce a texture. Crop one or more elements. Overlap the layers. Try changing the scale.

Create at least three different compositions. Do not try to make them perfect. Your objective is to discover possibilities.

composition A: photo + drawing + texture



composition B: a different crop and overlap



composition C: more abstract / changed scale

Developing the strongest idea

Look at your experiments together.

Which one has the strongest composition? Which one creates the most interesting transformation? Which one communicates something about architecture without simply showing a building?

Choose one and develop it further. You might remove unnecessary elements, add stronger contrasts, change the scale, introduce colour, increase abstraction or simplify the composition.

Think like an artist

At what point does an artwork stop being a representation of a building and become an artwork about shape, line, space and texture? Can both things happen at the same time?

write your thinking

Key words

mixed media · crop · overlap · abstraction · focal point

Chapter 16 - Review and project completion

Your final architectural artwork is the result of a process.

You began by observing the built environment. You collected information. You experimented with perspective, texture, line and photography. You transformed your observations. You combined different materials. You developed a composition.

Now it is time to evaluate what you have learned.

Looking back

Place your early architectural studies next to your final work. Think about the journey.

At the beginning, you may have been interested mainly in what a building looked like.

By the end, you may have become more interested in lines, shapes, textures, fragments, viewpoints, patterns, spaces and relationships.

This change is important. You are beginning to look at the built environment as an artist.

What makes a successful architectural artwork?

A successful artwork does not necessarily have to look realistic.

It might be successful because it creates a strong composition, communicates an idea, uses materials effectively, transforms its source material, creates visual interest, makes the viewer look carefully or presents an original viewpoint.

Ask yourself: What did I want the viewer to notice first? Did I achieve this?

Process reflection

Focus	Question	My answer
Observation	What did you discover by looking closely at architecture?	
Perspective	How did changing your viewpoint affect your drawings or photographs?	
Texture	Which architectural texture interested you most, and why?	
Line	How did your continuous-line drawings change the way you see buildings?	
Photography	Which photographic viewpoint produced the most unexpected result?	
Experimentation	Which experiment did not work, and what did you learn from it?	
Development	How did your final artwork develop from your original idea?	
Abstraction	How recognisable is the architecture in your final artwork? Does it matter?	

process reflection: write in full sentences

Artist's checklist

Before completing the project, make sure you have:

- ☐ Made observational studies of architecture.
- ☐ Explored shape and form.

- ☐ Investigated architectural textures.
- ☐ Practised perspective.
- ☐ Drawn the same architecture from different viewpoints.
- ☐ Completed a half-image reconstruction.
- ☐ Experimented with continuous-line drawing.
- ☐ Created architectural texture rubbings or recordings.
- ☐ Taken photographs of the built environment.
- ☐ Explored unusual viewpoints.
- ☐ Experimented with zoom and cropping.
- ☐ Created several mixed-media compositions.
- ☐ Explored overlap and abstraction.
- ☐ Developed one composition into a final outcome.
- ☐ Reflected on the development of your project.

Key vocabulary

Term	Meaning
Architecture	the design and construction of buildings and spaces
Built environment	the human-made surroundings in which we live and work
Perspective	a system for representing three-dimensional space on a two-dimensional surface
Vanishing point	the point towards which receding parallel lines appear to converge
Viewpoint	the position from which something is observed or photographed
Scale	the relative size of an object or element
Texture	the visual or tactile quality of a surface
Rubbing	an image created by rubbing a drawing material over a textured surface
Cropping	removing part of an image to change its composition or focus
Overlap	when one form or image partly covers another
Positive space	the area occupied by objects or forms
Negative space	the empty space around or between forms
Abstraction	transforming or simplifying a subject rather than representing it literally
Composition	the arrangement of visual elements within an artwork
Mixed media	an artwork made using more than one artistic medium
Observation	careful looking and recording of visual information
Distortion	deliberately changing the appearance, proportions or structure of something

Think like an artist

At the beginning of this unit, you were asked to look at familiar buildings differently.

Now look at your final artwork. Ask yourself: Can I still recognise the building that inspired me?

If yes, what remains? If no, what has replaced it?

Perhaps the building has disappeared and been transformed into lines, shapes, textures, spaces, patterns and relationships.

That transformation is at the heart of artistic practice. An artist does not simply copy the world. An artist can observe the world, take it apart, rearrange it and show it to us differently.

Final question. If architecture is designed to shape the spaces in which we live, what happens when an artist transforms architecture into an image? Does the artwork still belong to the building, or has it become something completely new?

final question: does the artwork still belong to the building?

Unit 8.3 - Design Brief

Designing with purpose

In Art and Design, you are not always asked to make something simply because it looks interesting. Sometimes you are asked to solve a problem, communicate an idea, respond to an audience or fulfil a particular purpose.

This is where design becomes different from making an artwork without a specific brief.

A designer might be asked to create a poster for an environmental campaign, a logo for a new company, packaging for a product, a book cover, a magazine layout, a piece of furniture, a website interface, a costume, a public artwork, or an identity for an event.

In each case, the designer has to make creative decisions, but those decisions are not completely free. There are requirements, limitations and expectations.

A good designer therefore has to ask: **What am I trying to achieve, who am I designing for, and why is this the best way to communicate my idea?**

Design is creative, but it is also purposeful.

On the graphic desk today

Letterpress blocks, a camera, scissors, collage papers, and a sentence: Make someone stop walking.

That sentence is a design brief in five words. This unit is about visual communication with a job to do.



IMAGE 8.3.01 - Design studio desk. Purpose: introduce briefs, layout, collage and process as the tools of Unit 8.3.

In this unit you will

- read and analyse a design brief
- identify client, audience, purpose and constraints
- turn a problem into questions and several ideas
- research, collect a moodboard and sketch thumbnails
- use hierarchy, typography and colour with reasons
- test a design and respond to feedback
- produce a campaign that answers a brief
- evaluate whether the design achieves its purpose

Chapter 17 - What is a design brief?

A **design brief** is a written description of a design problem or project.

It explains what needs to be designed and provides information that helps the designer understand the task.

A brief might tell you:

- what needs to be designed
- why it is needed

- who the intended audience is
- where or how it will be used
- what information it must communicate
- what materials or processes might be appropriate
- what limitations exist
- and sometimes when the project must be completed

For example:

Design a poster encouraging students at school to reduce the amount of single-use plastic they use. The poster should be displayed around the school and must be clear, engaging and suitable for students aged 11-16.

This brief contains several important pieces of information.

Part of the brief	In this example
The problem	students are using too much single-use plastic
The purpose	the poster should encourage a change in behaviour
The audience	students aged 11-16
The context	displayed around a school
The communication	the message must be clear and engaging

The brief therefore gives you a direction, but it does not tell you exactly what your poster should look like.

That part is your responsibility as a designer.



IMAGE 8.3.02 - A brief on the desk. Purpose: show that design starts with a problem on paper, not with decoration.

Artist or designer?

The distinction between art and design is not always clear.

Artists and designers both use visual elements, materials, techniques, imagination, experimentation, composition, colour, typography, images, symbols and personal ideas.

However, their intentions may be different.

An artist may create a painting to explore an emotion, experience, question or personal idea.

A designer often creates something for a particular purpose, audience or situation.

But this does not mean that art cannot communicate a message, or that design cannot be personal and expressive. In fact, some of the most interesting creative work exists somewhere between art and design.

Think like an artist

Imagine two posters. The first is created by an artist as an expressive exploration of climate change. The second is created by a designer for an environmental organisation that wants people to change their behaviour.

Both might use dramatic imagery, colour and typography. But the second designer must think particularly carefully about whether the audience will understand the message.

Is a design successful because the designer likes it, or because it achieves its purpose? There may not be a single answer.

write your thinking

Reading a brief

Before beginning a project, a designer should analyse the brief. Do not immediately start drawing. Instead, identify the important information.

One useful method is to divide the brief into five questions:

1. **WHAT?** What am I being asked to design?
2. **WHY?** Why does this design need to exist?
3. **WHO?** Who will see, use or experience it?
4. **WHERE?** Where and how will it be used?
5. **WHAT ARE THE LIMITATIONS?** What rules, materials, dimensions, information or deadlines must I consider?

Example. Create the cover for a fictional children's adventure book aimed at readers aged 9-12. The cover should communicate excitement and mystery and must include the title, author's name and an original illustration.

Question	Answer
WHAT?	a book cover
WHY?	to introduce and attract readers to a fictional adventure story
WHO?	children aged 9-12
WHERE?	on a book, physically or digitally
REQUIREMENTS?	title, author's name and original illustration
DESIGN CHALLENGE?	communicate both adventure and mystery while appealing to the audience

Notice that the brief does not tell us what colours to use, what image to draw, what typeface to choose, where the title should go, or what the composition should look like.

These are **design decisions**.

Practical task: five questions

Copy a brief your teacher gives you, or use the plastic-poster brief above. Answer WHAT, WHY, WHO, WHERE and LIMITATIONS in full sentences. Then list three decisions the brief does not make for you.

analyse the brief: five questions + three open decisions

Key words

brief · purpose · audience · context · design decision

Chapter 18 - Client, audience and constraints

Designers rarely work only for themselves.

They usually work for a **client**, an organisation, a company, a community or a particular **audience**.

The client is the person or organisation requesting the design. The audience is the group of people who will see, use or experience it.

These two groups are not always the same.

For example, a school might ask a designer to create a poster.

- **Client:** the school
- **Audience:** students
- **Purpose:** encourage students to recycle

The designer therefore has to satisfy the client while communicating effectively with the audience.

Designing for an audience

Imagine that you are designing a poster about cyber safety for younger students.

Would you use complicated vocabulary, tiny text, a dark and frightening image, long paragraphs, playful illustrations, bright colours or simple symbols?

Your choices depend on the audience. A design that works for a group of adults may not work for a group of children.

Before designing, ask:

- How old is the audience?
- What are they interested in?
- What might attract their attention?
- What visual language might they understand?
- What emotions should the design create?
- How quickly will they see or interact with the design?
- What information do they need?

The audience should influence your decisions, but it should not completely control your creativity.

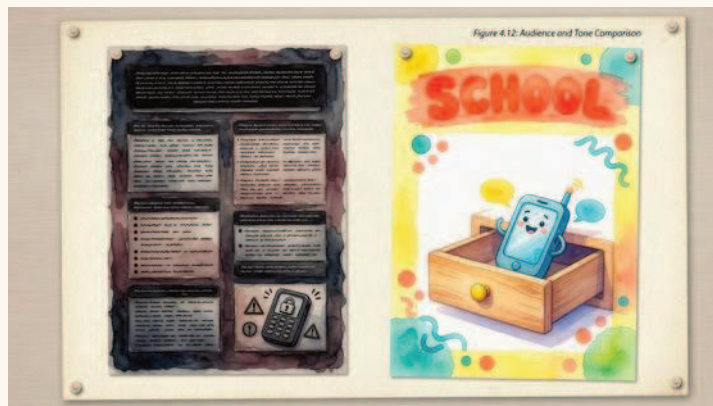


IMAGE 8.3.03 - Same message, two audiences. Purpose: compare a dense adult poster with a simpler student poster.

Design constraints

A **constraint** is something that limits or controls a design decision.

At first, constraints might seem negative. Why should creativity have rules?

But constraints can actually make designers more inventive.

Imagine being told: "Create anything you want." This gives you complete freedom, but it can also make it difficult to know where to begin.

Now imagine: "Create a poster using only black, white and one additional colour." Suddenly, you have a problem to solve.

The limitation may force you to think more carefully about contrast, hierarchy, composition, colour, typography and imagery.

Constraints can therefore become creative opportunities.

Common design constraints

Constraint	Example
Size	A4 poster, postcard, book cover, phone screen, billboard
Materials	recycled paper, cardboard, fabric, digital tools, found objects
Colour	colours that already belong to an identity
Content	title, date, logo, contact information, slogan
Time	a few lessons, not a year
Budget	some materials and print methods are too expensive
Audience	the design must be appropriate for the intended users

Practical task: client and audience

Rewrite this brief so the client and the audience are named separately:

A sports club wants a poster that will make Year 8 students come to after-school training.

Then list three constraints you would give yourself (size, colour, words).

client / audience / three constraints

Think like an artist

If a constraint makes the work stronger, was it really a limitation, or was it a tool?

write your thinking

Key words

client · audience · constraint · appropriate · opportunity

Chapter 19 - From problem to idea

A strong designer does not simply accept a brief. They question it.

Suppose the brief says: "Design a poster encouraging people to walk more."

You could immediately begin drawing a person walking. But first ask:

- Who needs to walk more: children, teenagers, adults, older people?
- Why should they walk more: health, environment, mental wellbeing, reducing traffic?
- Where will the poster be displayed?
- What information does the audience need?
- Should the design be serious, humorous, energetic or emotional?

The more precisely you understand the problem, the more meaningful your design decisions become.

The "Why?" question

One of the most useful questions in design is simply: **Why?**

Why this image? Why this colour? Why this typeface? Why this composition? Why this material? Why this size? Why this audience? Why this message?

A design becomes stronger when every important decision has a reason behind it.

This does not mean that every decision must be logical. Intuition, experimentation and emotion are important too. But you should be able to explain your choices.

From problem to idea

A design brief describes a problem. Your job is to transform that problem into a visual response.

This usually happens through several stages:

Brief → Research → Ideas → Experimentation → Development → Final Design

Do not expect your first idea to be your best idea. The first idea is simply a beginning.

Generate multiple ideas

Imagine you need to design a poster about saving water. Your first idea might be a photograph of a water tap. That is a reasonable starting point. But what else could you do?

1. A tap dripping into a desert landscape.
2. A glass of water shaped like a planet.
3. A large letter **W** constructed from water droplets.
4. A person's silhouette filled with an image of a dried landscape.
5. A humorous poster showing a fish asking humans to stop wasting water.

Each idea communicates the same general subject in a different way. This is why designers develop several possibilities before choosing one direction.

Practical task: five ideas, one brief

Use the brief: Design a poster encouraging people to walk more.

Write five genuinely different concepts in words and tiny sketches. Do not finish them. Circle the one that is not your first idea, and say why it might work.

five different concepts for the walking poster

Key words

problem · concept · why · first idea · alternative

Chapter 20 - Research, inspiration and moodboard

Research is an important part of the design process.

Research helps you understand the subject, the audience, existing designs, visual conventions, relevant artists and designers, materials, techniques, cultural references and possible solutions.

Research does not mean copying what someone else has done. Instead, research helps you discover possibilities.

Visual research

If you are designing a poster about plastic pollution, you might investigate photographs of plastic waste, ocean pollution, environmental campaigns, recycling symbols, activist posters, typography, colour associations and contemporary graphic design.

You might discover that many environmental campaigns use green and blue. That raises another question: **Should you follow this visual convention, or deliberately avoid it?**

Following a convention can make a message immediately recognisable. Breaking a convention can make your design stand out. Both can be successful.

Inspiration and originality

Designers are influenced by other designers. Artists are influenced by other artists. This is normal.

Creative work develops through looking, questioning, collecting and transforming ideas.

However, there is an important difference between inspiration and copying.

Copying. You reproduce someone else's image or design with little meaningful change.

Inspiration. You study an idea, understand how it works and then transform what you have learned into something new.

For example, you might study the bold typography of protest posters. You could then use what you learned about scale, contrast and composition in a completely different project.

Ask yourself: **What have I learned from this design rather than simply what does it look like?**

Ethics

Do not copy existing commercial logos or campaign posters. Do not use racist, sexist or mocking stereotypes "for impact". Influence is allowed. Substitution is not.

The moodboard

A **moodboard** is a collection of visual references used to establish the direction of a project.

A moodboard might include photographs, drawings, colour palettes, textures, typography, patterns, materials, objects, words, artists, designers or visual details.

The purpose is not simply to make a beautiful page. A moodboard should help you communicate the visual atmosphere you want to explore.

Suppose your brief is: Design a poster for a fictional music festival celebrating nature.

You might collect images showing forests, flowers, movement, musical instruments, crowds, natural textures, organic shapes, hand-drawn lettering and earthy colours.

Then identify common qualities. Perhaps your research suggests: **organic, energetic, natural, colourful, handmade.**

These words can become part of your design direction.



IMAGE 8.3.04 - A moodboard. Purpose: collect atmosphere (colour, texture, objects) before deciding the layout.

Practical task: moodboard

Build a moodboard for one of these briefs: plastic in school, walk more, or a nature music festival. Include at least eight pieces (photos you took, swatches, type scraps, textures). Write five direction words underneath.

moodboard notes: eight sources + five direction words

Key words

research · convention · inspiration · copying · moodboard

Chapter 21 - Sketching, selecting and developing

Once you understand the brief, begin generating ideas.

Do not worry about making your drawings beautiful. At this stage, the purpose of sketching is to think visually.

Small, quick sketches are called **thumbnail sketches**.

A thumbnail allows you to test composition, scale, placement, hierarchy, image and text relationships, and positive and negative space.

You might create ten small versions of a poster before choosing three to develop further.

This is much more efficient than spending an hour carefully drawing one idea that does not work.



IMAGE 8.3.05 - Thumbnail sketches. Purpose: many small compositions before committing to one.

Quantity before quality

During early development, try not to judge every idea immediately. Some ideas will be weak. That is normal. A weak idea can lead to a stronger one.

Think of the process as a conversation between you and your ideas:

- What if I changed this?
- What happens if the image becomes much larger?
- What if there is almost no text?
- What if I remove the colour?
- What if the design is deliberately confusing?

Experimentation creates possibilities.

Selecting an idea

Eventually, you need to choose which ideas to develop. Do not simply choose your favourite drawing. Evaluate the ideas against the brief.

Test	Ask
Purpose	Does it communicate the purpose?
Audience	Would the intended audience respond to it?
Interest	Does it attract attention?
Clarity	Can important information be understood quickly?
Practical	Can you produce it with the materials, time and skills you have?
Original	Does it offer a personal or unexpected interpretation?

Developing the design

Choosing an idea does not mean the design is finished. This is where development begins.

Take your strongest idea and change it. Experiment with colour, scale, composition, typography, imagery, materials, texture, contrast, cropping, repetition, layering, and positive and negative space.

Keep evidence of these experiments. Your sketchbook should show the journey from the first idea to the final solution.

Imagine that your poster contains a photograph of a tree. You might test:

- **Version A:** large tree in the centre
- **Version B:** tree cropped so that only part of it is visible
- **Version C:** several small trees arranged as a pattern
- **Version D:** tree combined with typography

Each version changes the meaning and visual impact. There is no rule saying that the first solution must remain unchanged. A designer's job is to test possibilities and make informed decisions.



IMAGE 8.3.06 - Logo and mark development. Purpose: simplification across thumbnails, then colour tests.

Practical task: ten thumbnails, then two developments

For your current brief, draw ten thumbnails in ten minutes. Circle three. Develop two of those as slightly larger sketches with notes on colour and type.

ten thumbnails

two developed versions with notes

Key words

thumbnail · hierarchy · iteration · development · selection

Chapter 22 - Hierarchy, typography and colour

Visual hierarchy

One of the most important concepts in graphic design is **visual hierarchy**.

Hierarchy means that some elements appear more important than others.

Think about a poster. What do you notice first? Perhaps:

SAVE OUR OCEANS

Then: Plastic is killing marine life.

Then: Join the school clean-up, Friday 3:30 pm.

The designer has created an order for the viewer's attention.

You can make something more prominent by changing size, position, contrast, colour, weight, spacing, shape, or surrounding empty space.

A large headline usually attracts attention before small supporting information.

A successful design does not necessarily make everything equally important. It helps the viewer understand where to look first, second and third.



IMAGE 8.3.07 - Visual hierarchy. Purpose: a poster that is read in a planned order: headline, reason, then time and place.

Typography as design

Typography is not simply about choosing a font. Typography is the visual design of written language.

The typeface you choose can change the personality of a message.

Compare: **SAVE WATER**

- A heavy, bold typeface might feel powerful.
- A handwritten typeface might feel personal.
- A delicate serif typeface might feel elegant.
- A playful rounded typeface might feel suitable for children.

Ask: **Does the typography communicate the same idea as the imagery?**

If the poster is about an emergency but the lettering looks playful and decorative, the visual language may become confusing. Sometimes this contradiction is intentional. But it should be a conscious decision.



IMAGE 8.3.08 - Serif and sans-serif. Purpose: two letterform families and the jobs they often do.



IMAGE 8.3.09 - Letters as objects. Purpose: experimental letterforms that can become part of a campaign image.

Colour and meaning

Colour can influence how a design is perceived. Different colours can suggest different associations.

Red can suggest danger, urgency or energy. Blue can suggest calm, trust or technology. Green can suggest nature or growth. Yellow can suggest optimism or warning. Black can suggest authority, sophistication or seriousness.

But colour does not have one universal meaning. Cultural context, personal experience and combinations of colours all influence interpretation.

A designer should therefore ask: **What does this colour communicate in this particular context?**

Colour can suggest, but it does not have one meaning



IMAGE 8.3.10 - Colour can suggest. Purpose: five colours with possible associations, not as laws.

Practical task: corridor test

Sketch a poster at A6 with a clear first, second and third read. Pin it at the end of a table. Can a partner name the message from two metres? If not, increase contrast and scale, reduce words.

A6 poster: first, second, third read

Curiosity

The word **poster** became common with colour lithography in the nineteenth century, when streets filled with printed images. Toulouse-Lautrec's theatre posters were advertisements and artworks at the same time. Unit 8.3 lives in that overlap.

Key words

hierarchy · typography · typeface · serif · sans-serif · association

Chapter 23 - Testing, feedback and evaluation

Before considering your design finished, **test** it.

Show it to someone else. Ask them:

- What do you notice first?
- What do you think the design is about?
- Who do you think it is for?
- What emotion does it create?
- Is anything confusing?
- What information do you remember?
- What would you change?

Do not ask only "Do you like it?" Like and dislike are not always useful measures of success.

A better question is: **Does the design achieve its purpose?**

A design can be visually unusual and still be successful. A design can also be beautiful and still fail to communicate.

Responding to feedback

Feedback is part of the design process.

If someone suggests a change, you do not have to accept it automatically. Instead, consider: Why are they making this suggestion?

Perhaps they could not read the text. Perhaps the image was confusing. Perhaps the message was not clear. Perhaps they noticed something that you had not considered.

Feedback gives you another perspective. The final decision remains yours, but a good designer is willing to listen, question and improve.

Evaluating the final design

At the end of a project, evaluate your work.

Do not simply write: "I like my design because it looks good."

A stronger evaluation explains what you did, why you did it and how successful it was.

Focus	Ask
The brief	Did you meet the requirements?
The audience	Is the design appropriate for the intended audience?
Communication	Is the message clear?
Visual elements	How did you use colour, line, shape, texture, typography, composition?
Materials	Were your processes appropriate?
Development	How did your ideas change?
Strengths	What works particularly well?
Weaknesses	What could be improved?
Next steps	If you had more time, what would you change?

Practical task: five-person test

Show two versions of a design to five people for five seconds each. Record what they noticed first and what they thought the message was. Keep one change. Reject one suggestion, with a reason.

test notes: five responses, one keep, one reject

Key words

test · feedback · purpose · evaluation · refine

Chapter 24 - Practical project: responding to a design brief

The designer's process

A design project can be summarised as a cycle. This is not always a perfectly straight line. You may return to research after developing an idea. You may discover that your chosen solution does not work. You may go back to sketching. You may completely change direction.

That is not failure. Design is an **iterative** process.

A designer's process



This is a cycle, not a straight line. You can go back.

IMAGE 8.3.11 - A designer's process. Purpose: ten steps from understanding the brief to evaluating the outcome.

The brief

Design a visual campaign encouraging students to spend less time on their phones and more time engaging with the physical world around them.

Your campaign should be aimed at students aged 11-16.

You may choose to create a poster, a series of posters, a social media campaign, an illustrated advertisement, a photographic campaign, or another appropriate visual format.

Your design must communicate a clear message and demonstrate thoughtful consideration of its audience.

Step 1 - Analyse

Write down: What is the problem? Who is the audience? What is the purpose? Where will the design be seen? What information must be included? What limitations will you impose on yourself?

Step 2 - Research

Investigate advertising campaigns, public information posters, contemporary graphic design, typography, photographic approaches, colour schemes and visual symbols.

Choose examples that genuinely influence your thinking. For each example, explain: What works? Why does it work? What could you learn from it?

Step 3 - Generate ideas

Create at least six different visual concepts. Do not fully develop them. Use quick sketches, notes and annotations. Try to make the ideas genuinely different from one another.

Step 4 - Develop

Choose your strongest two or three concepts. Experiment with composition, colour, typography, imagery, scale, cropping, materials and visual effects. Record your decisions in your sketchbook.

Step 5 - Test

Show your designs to another person. Ask: What do you notice first? What do you think the message is? Who do you think the design is aimed at? What emotion does it create? Is anything confusing? Which version is most effective, and why?

Record the feedback.

Step 6 - Final design

Create your final design. Make sure that the message is clear, the audience has been considered, the composition is intentional, typography is readable, imagery supports the message, and the final outcome responds to the original brief.



IMAGE 8.3.12 - A poster with hierarchy. Purpose: image, colour fields and a clear place for a title working together.

Submit

- analysed brief
- research with annotations
- at least six concepts
- two or three developments
- test notes
- final campaign piece
- 80-120 word designer statement

Challenge: break the brief

Once you have created a successful response, challenge yourself.

Create a second version of the same campaign that communicates the opposite visual mood.

- **Version A:** serious, dramatic and emotionally powerful

- **Version B:** humorous, playful and unexpected

The message can remain similar, but the visual language should change.

Compare the two. Which communicates more effectively, and why?

campaign plan: analyse, six concepts, chosen direction

version A and version B: opposite moods

Key words

campaign · iteration · concept · test · designer statement

Chapter 25 - Design is problem-solving

The most important idea in this unit is that design is a form of creative **problem-solving**.

When you receive a brief, you are not being asked simply: "Can you make something attractive?"

You are being asked: **Can you find an effective visual solution to this problem?**

This changes the way you work.

Instead of	You begin to ask
What should I draw?	What needs to be communicated?
What colour do I like?	Which colour supports the message?
Does this look good?	Does this work for the audience?
Is my first idea good enough?	What other possibilities could I explore?

These questions move you from simply making images towards thinking like a designer.

Artist's question

Designers make choices. But choices can also be questioned.

Consider these statements:

- "Good design should be beautiful."
- "Good design should communicate."
- "Good design should solve a problem."
- "Good design should challenge the viewer."
- "Good design should be useful."

Do you agree with all of them?

Can a design be successful without being beautiful? Can something ugly be good design? Can a design communicate too much? Can a design communicate without using words? Can breaking a design rule make the design stronger?

There are no simple answers.

The purpose of these questions is to make you aware that design is not only about what something looks like. It is about what it does, how it works and what it makes people think or feel.

Think like an artist

If someone saw your design without speaking to you, would they understand what you wanted to communicate?

That question is at the heart of visual communication.

would a stranger understand? write what they would see first

Key vocabulary

Term	Meaning
Audience	the people who will see, use or experience a design
Brief	a description of a design task, including its purpose and requirements
Client	the person or organisation requesting a design
Constraint	a limitation or requirement that affects the design
Concept	the central idea behind a design
Design development	the process of improving and refining an idea
Design solution	the final response to a design problem
Feedback	responses and observations from other people that can help improve a design
Hierarchy	the organisation of visual elements according to their importance
Iteration	repeating and modifying a process in order to improve the result
Moodboard	a collection of visual references used to establish the direction or atmosphere of a project
Target audience	the specific group of people for whom a design is intended
Typography	the visual design and arrangement of written language
Visual communication	the use of images, symbols, colour, typography and composition to communicate ideas

Reflection

Before you finish this unit, consider:

- Did I design what I wanted to make, or did I design what the problem required?
- How did my audience influence my decisions?
- Which design decision was the most successful?
- Which decision would I change?
- What did experimentation teach me?
- Did my final design solve the original problem?

And finally: **If someone saw my design without speaking to me, would they understand what I wanted to communicate?**

A designer does not simply make something. A designer makes decisions with a purpose.

Artist's checklist

- ☐ I analysed a brief using WHAT, WHY, WHO, WHERE and LIMITATIONS.
- ☐ I named the client and the audience separately.
- ☐ I used at least one constraint as a creative tool.
- ☐ I generated several genuinely different concepts.
- ☐ I built a moodboard and wrote direction words.
- ☐ I sketched thumbnails before committing.
- ☐ I can explain my hierarchy, type and colour choices.
- ☐ I tested the design and recorded feedback.
- ☐ My final outcome answers the original brief.
- ☐ I wrote a designer statement with reasons.

unit reflection: purpose, audience, one keep, one change

School Project

Year 8 Art & Design does not only live in the studio.

In the school project you use looking, making and visual communication for a brief that might also belong to humanities, science, music, languages or pastoral life.

The school itself becomes the client. Other students, families and teachers become the audience. The work has to do a job in a real place.

Chapter 26 - Art & Design in a school project

On the shared table today

A timetable, a corridor, a group of people who do not all think like you, and a real audience: the school.

Your teacher says: "This is not decoration sprinkled on someone else's poster. The visual thinking is part of the knowledge."



IMAGE 8.4.01 - A shared project table. Purpose: show collaboration: maps, portraits, camera, collage and more than one pair of hands.

Understanding a cross-curricular brief

A cross-curricular brief has two subjects in the room. The art is not an afterthought. It is how the idea becomes visible.

Examples (your teacher will give the live brief):

- a visual campaign about water use (science + design)
- a display on a historical street (humanities + architectural drawing)
- a poster and set of signs for a concert (music + typography)
- portraits of "who we are" for a community event (PSHE + portraiture)
- a wayfinding system for new students (pastoral + graphic design)

Read the brief the way you did in Unit 8.3:

Question	Ask
WHAT?	What are we being asked to make?
WHY?	What must people understand, feel or do?
WHO?	Who is the audience, and who is the client?
WHERE?	Corridor, hall, classroom, outdoor wall, digital screen?
LIMITATIONS?	Time, budget, materials, height, language, safety

Ask also: **Who is left out if we only use one language or one image style?**

Research and planning

Use the Year 8 process: observe, research, explore, experiment, develop, refine, create, reflect.

Add a project plan. Deadlines are a design constraint, like two colours on a poster.

When	Who	What	Evidence
Week 1		research and thumbnails	
Week 2		experiments	
Week 3		refine and make	
Week 4		install, present, evaluate	

Research might include:

- facts from the other subject (checked, dated, sourced)
- photographs of the real place where the work will hang
- audience tests (show a thumbnail to someone who is not in Art)
- artists and designers whose strategy you can steal, not whose picture you can copy

Collaboration

Collaboration is a skill, not a personality type.

Roles that help (rotate them so one person does not become "the artist" and everyone else fetches paper):

- **looker:** records visual research
- **maker:** tests materials
- **editor:** cuts what is weak
- **writer:** titles, labels, statement
- **producer:** times, lists, install plan

Disagree in the work, not in the corridor. If two ideas fight, make both as thumbnails and test them on someone outside the group.

Credit everyone. Do not put your name on a piece you did not help make. If someone is stuck, teach them a technique rather than taking the page away.

Working with others

Share kit. Photograph work before it is installed. Do not block fire exits or hang work where bags will destroy it. Ask before photographing people.

Visual communication

Choose a form that fits the audience and the place:

- a sequence of portraits
- a mixed-media map of a place
- a poster series
- a photographed alphabet of the theme
- small clay objects with labels
- a window display
- wayfinding signs

One strong form beats five weak ones. A corridor is not a gallery with unlimited walls. Hierarchy still applies: what do people see first while they are walking?

Developing a final outcome

Keep process visible. Schools often only display the polished end. Your group should also show one "how we got here" board: failures included.

Use Unit 8.3 tests: five seconds, two metres, "What do you think this is for?"

Adapt if the test fails. That is iteration, not a disaster.

Presentation and evaluation

Present standing up, work beside you:

1. the brief in one sentence
2. two decisions you made
3. one thing that went wrong and what it taught
4. what you would do with another week

Invite questions. Write down the useful ones.

Practical task: 40-minute mini brief

In pairs, design a one-page visual for this brief: Help new students find the art studio without using a map full of words.

Test it on someone who is not in Art. Revise once.

wayfinding thumbnail: no wordy map

School Project evidence

- brief copied in your own words
- research (including at least one other subject source)
- collaboration notes (who did what)
- experiments
- final outcome (or a fair photograph of an install)
- group evaluation + personal evaluation

Think like an artist

If a visitor only remembers one work, which should it be? If it is not yours, how can the group still succeed?

write your thinking

Key words

cross-curricular · client · collaboration · wayfinding · install

Extension and Exhibition

Chapter 27 - Building your portfolio

A **portfolio** is a sequenced collection of work that shows how you think, not only what you finished. Art schools, some jobs, and your future Year 9 teacher will care about range and process. It is not a pile. It is an argument: this is how I look, experiment and decide.



IMAGE 8.4.02 - A sequenced portfolio. Purpose: process sheets and finals presented as a set, not a pile.

What is a portfolio?

The word originally meant a case for carrying loose sheets. The container taught the idea: separate works, chosen, portable, ready to be reordered. A digital folder should still be edited with that care.

A Year 8 portfolio can be:

- a physical folder or A3 sleeve
- a sequenced sketchbook with tagged pages
- a carefully ordered set of photographs
- a mixture of the three

Whatever the container, the thinking is the same: **select, sequence, caption.**

Selecting your strongest work

Strongest does not always mean neatest. Choose work that shows looking, a decision, a risk, and at least once a finish.

From Year 8, aim to include:

- a portrait (observational or expressive)
- a figure or overlap study
- a clay head (photographed from two angles)
- an architectural drawing or mixed-media piece
- photographs you took
- typography / poster / campaign work
- one page of "failures that taught me"

If two pages say the same thing, keep the clearer one.

Process versus final outcomes

A portfolio with only finals looks like magic. A portfolio with only process looks unfinished.

Pair them:

- a gesture page facing a refined portrait
- a contact sheet facing a mixed-media architecture piece
- six weak logo thumbnails facing the tested mark
- a failed clay view facing the view that worked

The viewer should be able to follow a decision.

Editing and sequencing

Order matters. Try:

1. looking (observation)
2. experiment
3. a resolved piece
4. a different material
5. a design piece with an audience
6. reflection

Avoid putting three similar drawings in a row unless you are showing a series on purpose.

Read the sequence as a stranger. Where do you get bored? Cut there.

Presentation

- consistent margins
- no fizzy-drink stains
- labels: title, date, material, size
- photographs square-on, cropped, decent light
- original work in sleeves if your school uses a folder
- file names that a teacher can understand (Y8_portrait_final.jpg, not IMG_4402.jpg)

Writing about your work

Captions are short. Statements are longer. Both need reasons.

Caption example: Overlap study, ink, 20 min, corridor, March 2026. I filled the negative space so the crowd felt tighter.

Statement (80-120 words): what it is about, how you made it, which artists or ideas fed it, what you want the viewer to notice.

Avoid: "I like this because it looks nice." Prefer: "I chose charcoal because it smudges, which fitted a portrait about memory."

Practical task: 8-page mini portfolio

Choose eight pages or photographs from this year. Sequence them on a table. Photograph the sequence. Tomorrow, swap two pages and ask a partner which order is clearer.

Write a one-sentence caption for each piece.

portfolio sequence: eight titles in order + one-line captions

Curiosity

The word **portfolio** comes from a case for carrying loose sheets. Editing is the work. Anyone can collect. A designer chooses.

Key words

portfolio · sequence · series · caption · range · edit

Chapter 28 - Preparing an exhibition

An **exhibition** is a designed experience of looking.

It has an entrance, a path, pauses, labels and an ending. A classroom wall can be an exhibition if you treat it as one.



IMAGE 8.4.03 - A small school exhibition. Purpose: sequenced work, labels and a path for looking.

What makes an exhibition?

A pile of work on a table is a storage problem. An exhibition is a conversation with a visitor who has not been in your lessons.

Ask:

- What is the story of this wall?
- Where does the visitor start?
- Where do they slow down?
- What do they remember when they leave?

Possible Year 8 exhibition stories:

- Looking at people
- How we walk through buildings
- Words as pictures
- One year of decisions

Selecting work

Curate, do not dump. Ten strong pieces in a clear order will beat thirty mixed pieces. Include process if it helps the story.

A useful test: if you remove this piece, does the exhibition get weaker? If not, it does not need to be there.

Display and presentation

- hang at a shared centre line (eyes of the audience, not the tallest student)
- even gaps, unless you want a cluster on purpose
- consider a plinth or table for clay (safe from bags)
- lighting: avoid glare on glass and shine on clay
- 3D work needs space to walk around
- do not block doors, sockets or fire equipment

Walk the route as a visitor. Where do you get bored? Cut there.



IMAGE 8.4.04 - Titles and labels. Purpose: a shared hanging line, even gaps and small labels as designed objects.

Titles and labels

A label is a designed object. Keep a template:

Title Name, Year 8 Material, size, date One sentence (optional)

Do not write an essay on the wall. Put longer statements in a booklet or QR sheet if your teacher uses one.

Type on labels should be readable from a step away. Hierarchy still applies: title larger than the materials line.

Curating a small collection

Curating means choosing relationships.

Put two portraits together because they argue. Put a photograph of a window next to a drawn window. Leave one piece a little isolated so it feels important.

Think in groups of three: look, experiment, resolve.

Reflecting on your Year 8 journey

Return to the ten questions from the Course Introduction. You do not need new answers. You need changed answers, with evidence from the year.

Look at your first observational portrait beside your campaign poster. What can you do now that you could not do in September? What do you notice now that you used to walk past?

Exhibition jobs

- **curator:** order and story
- **registrar:** list of works
- **graphic designer:** labels and title wall
- **installer:** hanging and 3D safety
- **invigilator:** explain work to visitors (without talking over them)

Everyone still shows at least one piece.

Practical task: table exhibition

In groups of four, curate 12 pieces on two tables in 15 minutes. Write a three-word title. Invite another group to walk it in silence, then talk.

exhibition plan: title, order of works, labels

Think like an artist

If a portrait shows us how one person sees another person, and an exhibition shows us how a group sees a year of work, can either ever be completely objective?

Look at your final wall. What does it tell a visitor about the people you represented, the buildings you walked through, the messages you designed, and about you?

Year 8 letter: to my Year 7 self, one page

Reflect on Year 8

Write a letter to your Year 7 self (one page). Include: a material you feared, a portrait decision, a building you finally noticed, a poster test, and one question you still like not answering.

The artist's mindset, again

Look closely. Ask questions. Try something. Make mistakes. Try again. Develop your ideas. Make choices. Explain your thinking. Stay curious.

Art is not only about what you make. It is also about how you see, how you think and how you respond to the world.

Studio pages - Look, try, reflect

Use these sheets in lessons. They do not replace your sketchbook.
They are for working beside the teaching chapters of each unit.

How to use a studio page

Date the sheet. Draw first, write second. Photograph anything that will not fit.
One honest sentence is better than a paragraph of empty praise.

One spread per unit

Unit 8.1 · Portrait: People

Unit 8.2 · Built Environment

Unit 8.3 · Design Brief

Unit 8.4 · Portfolio and exhibition

Each spread gathers the timed tasks from every chapter of the unit:
work through them in order, or choose the ones your teacher sets.

Unit 8.1 studio page - Portrait: People

Unit 8.1. Date: _____ Name: _____

Learning focus

Think in relationships, then take risks: where one feature sits in relation to another matters more than outline, and a drawing does not have to be realistic to be successful. A head is planes, not a pancake with features stuck on.

Success criteria

- ☐ I looked more than I copied.
- ☐ I can name one visual element I used on purpose.
- ☐ I can name one principle of design I used on purpose.
- ☐ I have at least one experiment, including something that did not work.
- ☐ I can explain a decision in one sentence.

Timed tasks

1. Observational portrait from life: overall head first, features later. Then a second drawing using only proportions, large shapes, light and dark.
2. Three portraits of the same person: continuous line, distorted proportions, then line + shape + expressive colour.
3. One person, five emotions. Do not write the names. Swap with a classmate: can they identify them?
4. Movement studies: walking, running, jumping, stretching, turning, sitting, reaching.
5. Overlap figures until the page has rhythm, then a line-only version.
6. Clay portrait head in five stages: structure, features, refinement, expression, surface.
7. Personal portrait project: eight-step plan, three composition plans, one final with reflection.

Stage	My notes
Look	
Analyse	
Interpret	
Question	

Exit ticket

Today I noticed _____.

Tomorrow I will try _____.

This work is about _____.

Unit 8.2 studio page - Built Environment

Unit 8.2. Date: _____ Name: _____

Learning focus

Perspective is a tool and looking still wins. Buildings are giant texture collages that have to survive rain. What you leave out is a design decision.

Success criteria

- ☐ I looked more than I copied.
- ☐ I can name one visual element I used on purpose.
- ☐ I can name one principle of design I used on purpose.
- ☐ I have at least one experiment, including something that did not work.
- ☐ I can explain a decision in one sentence.

Timed tasks

1. A page of small architectural studies, each recording a different visual element: shape, form, line, tone, texture, colour.
2. Same building, three views: front, corner or side, then an unusual viewpoint. Which composition is strongest?
3. Texture library of at least six surfaces. For each: where, material, visual feel, how you could use it.
4. Complete a half-image from clues (line, proportion, perspective, texture), then a second version that changes the mood.
5. Three continuous-line architectural drawings: structure, texture, then increasingly abstract.
6. Photo hunt: whole building, close-up, unusual viewpoint, texture, reflection, almost-abstract crop.
7. Three mixed-media compositions from the same research. Choose the strongest and develop it.

Stage	My notes
Look	
Analyse	
Interpret	
Question	

Exit ticket

Today I noticed _____.

Tomorrow I will try _____.

This work is about _____.

Unit 8.3 studio page - Design Brief

Unit 8.3. Date: _____ Name: _____

Learning focus

Analyse the brief before drawing: WHAT, WHY, WHO, WHERE, LIMITATIONS. If everything is the same size, nothing is important. Constraints are the walls of the squash court.

Success criteria

- ☐ I looked more than I copied.
- ☐ I can name one visual element I used on purpose.
- ☐ I can name one principle of design I used on purpose.
- ☐ I have at least one experiment, including something that did not work.
- ☐ I can explain a decision in one sentence.

Timed tasks

1. Analyse a brief with WHAT, WHY, WHO, WHERE and LIMITATIONS. List three decisions the brief does not make for you.
2. Five genuinely different concepts for "walk more". Circle one that is not your first idea.
3. Moodboard of at least eight pieces plus five direction words.
4. Ten thumbnails in ten minutes. Circle three. Develop two with notes on colour and type.
5. A6 poster with a planned first, second and third read. Corridor test from two metres.
6. Five-person, five-second test of two versions. Record what they noticed first.
7. Phone campaign: analyse the brief, six concepts, develop two, test one. Then a second version in the opposite mood.
8. Live school brief: analyse, plan four weeks, 40-minute pair test.

Stage	My notes
Look	
Analyse	
Interpret	
Question	

Exit ticket

Today I noticed _____.

Tomorrow I will try _____.

This work is about _____.

Unit 8.4 studio page - Portfolio and exhibition

Unit 8.4. Date: _____ Name: _____

Learning focus

A portfolio is an argument, not a pile. An exhibition is a designed experience of looking.

Success criteria

- ☐ I looked more than I copied.
- ☐ I can name one visual element I used on purpose.
- ☐ I can name one principle of design I used on purpose.
- ☐ I have at least one experiment, including something that did not work.
- ☐ I can explain a decision in one sentence.

Timed tasks

1. Eight-page mini portfolio: sequence on a table, photograph, swap two. Write a one-sentence caption for each page.
2. Table exhibition: 12 pieces, three-word title, labels, silent walk. Then a one-page letter to your Year 8 self.

Stage	My notes
Look	
Analyse	
Interpret	
Question	

Exit ticket

Today I noticed _____.

Tomorrow I will try _____.

This work is about _____.

Unit 8.1 assessment sheet - Portrait: People

Name: _____ Group: _____ Date: _____

Evidence	Where is it?	Strong / developing / starting
Research and looking		
Experiments		
Final outcome		
Vocabulary in the statement		
Unit focus (portrait / clay / statement)		

Teacher + student comments

Student: what I want noticed. Teacher: one strength, one next step.

Unit 8.1 comments and next step

Unit 8.2 assessment sheet - Built Environment

Name: _____ Group: _____ Date: _____

Evidence	Where is it?	Strong / developing / starting
Research and looking		
Experiments		
Final outcome		
Vocabulary in the statement		
Unit focus (place / viewpoint / mixed media)		

Teacher + student comments

Student: what I want noticed. Teacher: one strength, one next step.

Unit 8.2 comments and next step

Unit 8.3 assessment sheet - Design Brief

Name: _____ Group: _____ Date: _____

Evidence	Where is it?	Strong / developing / starting
Research and looking		
Experiments		
Final outcome		
Vocabulary in the statement		
Unit focus (audience / hierarchy / test)		

Teacher + student comments

Student: what I want noticed. Teacher: one strength, one next step.

Unit 8.3 comments and next step

Year 8 exhibition inventory

Title	Chapter / unit	Material	Size	Wall / plinth	Label done

hanging plan / route for visitors

Appendix / Reference

These pages are a toolkit. Use them during every unit, not only at the end of the year.

A - Visual elements

The visual elements are the raw materials of looking and making. Year 7 introduced them. Year 8 expects you to choose them.

When you write about work, try: "I used **line** to..." not "I used lots of things."

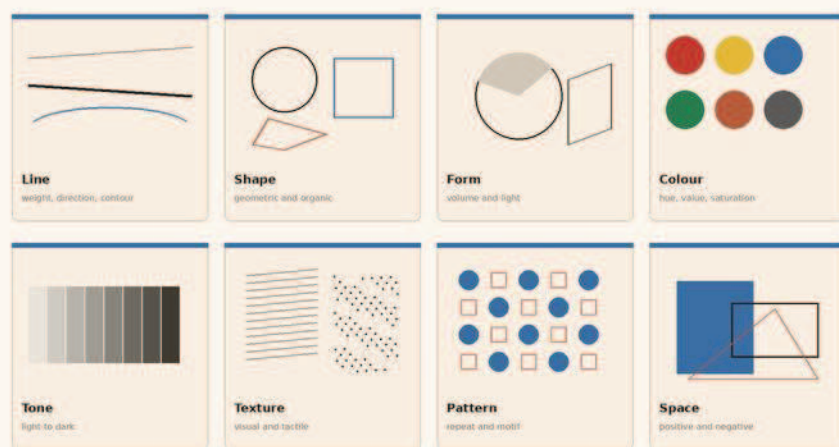


IMAGE A.01 - Visual elements board. Purpose: a quick map of line, shape, form, colour, tone, texture, pattern and space.

Line

A mark that connects two points, or the edge where two shapes meet.

Line can be contour (edge), gesture (action), or implied (a row of windows the eye completes). Weight, speed and direction change feeling. In Unit 8.1 a blind contour is a record of looking. In Unit 8.2 a single line can walk through a building until it becomes abstract.

Shape

A flat, enclosed area. Geometric (circle, rectangle) or organic (cloud, stain, a torn collage edge).

Portraits are full of negative shapes between arm and waist. Architecture is full of repeating window rectangles. A letterform is a shape before it is a sound.

Form

Shape with volume. Light on one side, shadow on the other.

Clay heads are form. A shaded cheek is form on paper. Architects combine cubes, cylinders and blocks. Drawing creates the illusion of form. Sculpture creates actual form.

Colour

Hue (which colour), value (light/dark), saturation (intensity).

In design, colour is also code: stop, go, luxury, warning. Red can suggest urgency or energy. Blue can suggest calm or trust. Green can suggest nature. These are not laws. Always test colour on the actual paper, not only in your head, and always ask what it communicates in this context.

Tone

The scale from light to dark, with or without hue.

Tone makes form believable and posters readable from a distance. If everything is mid-grey, nothing sits forward. In an observational portrait, find the darkest dark and the lightest light before you decorate features.

Texture

Tactile (real) or visual (drawn or photographed).

Architecture is a texture library: brick, peeling paint, rust, glass. Hair in a portrait is a texture problem as much as a shape problem. A rubbing records a surface directly. Mixed media can be texture, not only describe it.

Pattern

A motif that repeats.

Window grids, brick bonds, a photographic alphabet in a consistent crop. Pattern can comfort or, if broken, can wake the eye. A texture becomes a pattern when you repeat a fragment until the original surface is hard to name.

Space

Positive (the thing) and negative (the air).

Overlap, scale and perspective create depth. Cropping creates tension. Empty space is not wasted space if you chose it. In overlapping figures, the gap between arm and body may be the most honest shape on the page.

Your turn: element hunt

Pick any artwork in this book. Name three visual elements doing the heavy lifting. Cover the caption with your hand first.

element hunt: artwork, three elements, one sentence each

B - Principles of design

If elements are ingredients, principles are recipes: how you organise the elements.

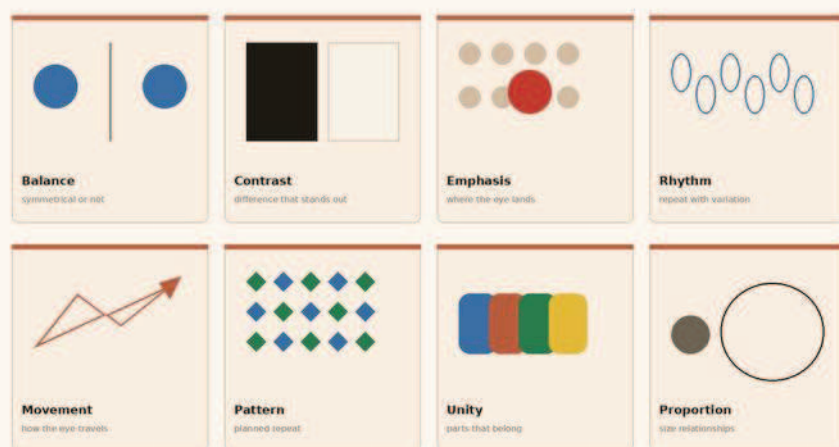


IMAGE B.01 - Principles of design board. Purpose: balance, contrast, emphasis, rhythm, movement, pattern, unity, proportion as visual diagrams.

Balance

Visual weight. Symmetrical balance feels stable. Asymmetrical balance can feel lively if a small dark shape equals a large light one. A poster with all the type on one side needs a counterweight: an image, a colour field, or empty space used on purpose.

Contrast

Difference: light/dark, rough/smooth, huge/tiny, serif/sans, serious/playful.

Contrast creates emphasis and readability. A corridor test fails when there is not enough contrast. Two campaign versions in opposite moods are a contrast experiment.

Emphasis

The focal point: where the eye lands first.

If you have three emphases, you have none. Hierarchy is emphasis with an order: first, second, third.

Rhythm

Repetition with beat. Figures walking, windows repeating, letters in a line. Vary the beat so it does not lull. Overlapping figures can turn a walk into a drum pattern.

Movement

How the eye travels through the work.

Diagonals, pointing arms, a vanishing point, a large letter leading to a small caption, a line taken for a walk. Gesture drawing captures the body's movement. Composition creates the viewer's movement.

Pattern

As a principle, pattern is planned repeat used on purpose (not accident). It can be structure (a grid) or surface (wallpaper, a texture library tiled).

Unity

Do the parts belong together?

Materials, colours and type can unify a messy set of ideas. Unity is not sameness. A mixed-media architecture piece has unity if every layer has a job.

Proportion

Size relationships: eyes on a head, a logo on a poster, a clay head on a neck, a label under a painting.

Awkward proportion can be a mistake or a decision. Know which you are doing. Distortion in an expressive portrait is proportion used as language.

Remember

Elements = what you use. Principles = how you organise. In critiques, try: "I used **contrast of tone** to create **emphasis** on the doorway."

Your turn: principle hunt

Look at your final portrait, your mixed-media building and your campaign poster. Name one principle each, with a reason.

three works, three principles, three reasons

C - Art & Design vocabulary

Glossary of key terms used throughout Year 8. British spellings.

Abstraction. Simplifying or departing from exact appearance while keeping a link to something seen or felt.

Armature. An inner support for clay or other sculpture.

Artist statement. A short piece of writing that explains intention, process and decisions.

Audience. The people who will see, use or experience a design. Not "everyone".

Blind contour. Drawing the edge of a subject without looking at the page.

Brief. A written description of a design problem, including purpose and requirements.

Built environment. Human-made surroundings: buildings, streets, interiors.

Client. The person or organisation requesting a design.

Collage. Composing by cutting, tearing and combining existing images and papers.

Composition. The arrangement of visual elements in a space.

Concept. The central idea behind a design.

Constraint. A limit that shapes decisions (two colours, A3, twelve words).

Continuous line. A drawing made without lifting the tool.

Crop. Where you cut the edge of an image; a viewpoint decision.

Curate. To select, sequence and present work for an audience.

Distortion. Deliberately changing appearance or proportions.

Emphasis. The part that dominates.

Exhibition. A designed experience of looking, with a path, pauses and labels.

Expressive. Using distortion, mark or colour to communicate feeling, not only likeness.

Facade. The face of a building.

Feedback. Responses from other people used to improve a design.

Form. A three-dimensional shape or object.

Gesture drawing. Fast drawing of a whole pose, capturing action.

Hierarchy. The order in which a viewer reads information.

Identity. The qualities that communicate who a person is.

Iteration. Repeating and modifying a process in order to improve the result.

Letterform. The designed shape of a letter.

Logo. A designed mark standing for an organisation or idea.

Maquette. A small trial sculpture.

Massing. The big 3D shapes of a building, before detail.

Mixed media. More than one material used together on purpose.

Moodboard. A collection of visual references used to set atmosphere and direction.

Negative space. The shapes of the gaps.

Observation. Drawing or recording from looking, not only from memory or a phone.

Perspective. A system for drawing depth (one-point, two-point).

Portfolio. An edited, sequenced collection of work.

Positive space. The area occupied by the main subject or forms.

Proportion. Size relationships between parts.

Refinement. Making deliberate adjustments to strengthen an artwork.

Representation. A version of a person, place or idea, made through choices.

Rubbing. An image created by rubbing a drawing material over a textured surface.

Sans-serif. Letterforms without feet.

Serif. Letterforms with small feet at stroke ends.

Target audience. The specific group of people for whom a design is intended.

Texture. The visual or tactile quality of a surface.

Thumbnail. A tiny, fast design sketch used to compare options.

Typography. Arranging letterforms for reading and feeling.

Unity. The sense that the parts of an artwork belong together.

Vanishing point. Where receding parallel lines appear to meet.

Viewpoint. Where the maker stands (or where the camera stands).

Visual communication. Using image, type and layout to send a message.

Wayfinding. Design that helps people find their way through a place.

Wordmark. A logo made primarily of letterforms.

Your turn: five words

Without looking back, define hierarchy, gesture, negative space, brief and curate in one sentence each. Then check.

five definitions in your own words

D - Artists, designers and references

Short reference pages connected to the projects. These are starting points for research, not scripts to copy. Record the source you actually used (book, museum site, teacher print-out).

Named artists appear here as **strategies**. Plates in this book are original teaching illustrations, not reproductions of copyrighted paintings.

Portrait and figure (Unit 8.1)

Maker	Why look	Steal this, not the picture
Kathe Kollwitz	charcoal, empathy, dark tone	tone as feeling
Alberto Giacometti	thin figures, looking as searching	hesitation in the line
Edgar Degas	dancers, unusual crops	crop and movement
Giacomo Balla / Futurists	repeating limbs	several moments in one image
Henri Cartier-Bresson	the "decisive moment"	freeze ordinary walking
Henri Matisse	a single flowing line, earned by looking	confident simplification
Terracotta Army, Xi'an; Benin bronze heads; Egyptian funerary portraits	likeness in 3D across cultures	the head as presence

Built environment (Unit 8.2)

Maker	Why look	Steal this
Paul Klee / Bauhaus	drawing as a line for a walk; art, craft and architecture together	line as journey
Eadweard Muybridge	motion sequences, 1870s	looking with new tools
Berenice Abbott	city photographs, viewpoint	looking up / looking along
Zaha Hadid	movement in structure	curve and flow as architecture
Gordon Matta-Clark	cuts through buildings	seeing inside structure
Local street / your school	the real subject	your own photographs

Type, poster, brand (Unit 8.3)

Maker	Why look	Steal this
Bauhaus designers	type, grid, economy	few elements, strong hierarchy
Toulouse-Lautrec	posters as art and advert	image and type as one
Paula Scher	loud type, maps of words	type as image
Marcel Duchamp, Fountain, 1917	context can change meaning	the question "why is this here?"
Student work from previous years (if shown)	what is possible here	ambition, not copying

Did you know?

You may study a famous artwork in class from a book or a museum website. You still may not photocopy it and submit it as your project. Influence is allowed. Substitution is not.

Sources

Write: title, maker, date if known, where you saw it (site or book), date you accessed it. Internet images without a maker are weak research.

E - Assessment and reflection

Project checklist

Use at the end of Units 8.1, 8.2, 8.3 and the School Project.

- ☐ I understood the brief or starting question in my own words.
- ☐ I recorded from looking (drawing, photo, rubbing, or clay from a real head).
- ☐ I have experiments, including at least one that failed usefully.
- ☐ I can name visual elements and principles I used on purpose.
- ☐ I made decisions I can explain.
- ☐ I presented work (title, materials, date).
- ☐ I wrote a statement with reasons.
- ☐ I photographed the work for my portfolio.

Self-assessment questions

1. What was I trying to communicate?
2. Where does the viewer look first, and is that what I wanted?
3. Which experiment changed my direction?
4. What would I do with one more lesson?
5. What will I reuse next project?
6. Did I design what I wanted to make, or what the problem required?
7. If someone saw this without speaking to me, would they understand?

Vocabulary for discussing artwork

Instead of nice / weird / random, try:

- The **contrast** between... makes...
- The **crop** turns the building into...
- The **hierarchy** is unclear because...
- The **gesture** captures...
- The **negative space** is doing more work than the figure.
- The **audience** might misread this as...
- I would **refine** this by...
- This **constraint** forced me to...
- The **sequence** of the portfolio argues that...

Reflection prompts

- I used to think a portrait was... Now I think...
- A place I never noticed was...
- A letter I found in the environment was...
- Collaboration was hard when...
- The piece I am proudest of is not the neatest because...
- A brief stopped me from... and that made the work better because...
- Next year I want to take a risk with...

End-of-year reflection

Revisit the ten questions from the Course Introduction. Tick any whose answer moved. Write the new answer in two sentences, with a Year 8 piece as evidence.